DeltaAdora

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34683859.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra/Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Scorpia (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Marlena (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), He-Man | Adam

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe, Deltarune Universe, SOUL controling Adora, idk what else to tag this as lmao, They/Them Pronouns for Adora (She-Ra), non binary adora

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2021-10-24 Completed: 2021-11-06 Words: 24,844 Chapters: 3/3

DeltaAdora

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34683859.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra/Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Scorpia (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Marlena (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), He-Man | Adam

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe, Deltarune Universe, SOUL controling Adora, idk what else to tag this as lmao, They/Them Pronouns for Adora (She-Ra), non binary adora

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2021-10-24 Completed: 2021-11-06 Words: 24,844 Chapters: 3/3

DeltaAdora

by curiousscientistkae

Summary

Deltarune Au. Adora has been enjoying their time in the Dark World. They have made friends, fell in love, and been on adventures. However, the thing that allows them to go there starts to get on their nerves and they have no idea what to do about it.

Notes

So here is the short story I have! I have to say many ideas came from Athetos!! They helped give me ideas on what characters should be who and what not. We also just talk a lot about Deltarune so aksskjakjfkjabfsajk. So please go check xem out, xe write amazing stuff!!!

anyway yeah its not a 1:1 with deltarune but still. idk what else other than T just for like swearing and like the SOUL fucking with Adora ya know?

(also i did try my best to catch myself but if i used she/her on adora in this and I missed it, please let me know I reread this like 5 times but you never know)

See the end of the work for more notes

Welcome To The Jungle

“Adora! It’s time to wake up!” Adora hears their mother’s footsteps treading over the hardwood and then carpeting. The sound of curtains being drawn fills the air and is swiftly followed by bright, warm rays of light from the sun. Adora winces. Even with their eyes closed, they feel the beams squeezing through and disturbing their slumber. They pull the covers over their face, hoping to go back into the darkness.

“Adora. Do you want to be late for school?” Their mother, Marlena, asks. She grabs the covers and lifts them up, destroying their child’s cocoon. Adora looks up at her, slightly annoyed. The older woman’s blue eyes, several shades darker than Adora’s, return the gaze. Her reddish brown hair is tied into a familiar braid.

“Get up, honey. Breakfast will be ready soon.”

Adora watches her leave, her frame disappearing into the hallway. Once gone, they sigh before sitting up. Dark blonde hair sticks up all over the place, it's in a desperate need for a brushing. Another day is at hand. More listening to their teacher, Huntara, talk about whatever she has up her sleeve today. And, more wondering if any poor sap (or themself) will fall asleep today. Huntara always loves to drop books to startle those who end up in that situation.

Before stepping out of bed, Adora checks something. Eyes flick to the birdcage across from the foot of their bed, sitting square in a red wagon. Rusted, busted, and burst wide open. Absolutely no shocker there. Adora looks into themself, literally. Dead center inside their chest is a red, floating heart, almost cartoon shaped in nature.

A SOUL it is called, at least according to Glimmer and Bow. They have no idea how long they have had it, maybe all their life. Never noticed it until some time ago, beating inside their chest. Recently,

it has made much more of an appearance as they venture into the Dark World.

Whatever this thing is, this *SOUL,* it is ***not*** theirs. It's neither their heart or soul. The only thing they know for sure is it belongs to someone else and commands them to do, say, and act out things they normally would never do. Some unforeseen eninity has made Adora their puppet. And by the looks of it, they don't want to let go of them anytime soon.

So many nights does Adora, after their time with their friends, reach into their chest. Fingers gripping the SOUL tight and yanking it straight out of their chest. No matter how painful tearing it out is, no matter how much effort it takes, no matter how tired they are, Adora pries the thing out of their chest and chucks it into the birdcage during the middle of the night. All they want is some semblance of peace, of *control* over themself again.

The SOUL sure is determined not to allow this to happen.

Adora sighs. They swing their legs over their bed and stand on their feet. The room they call their own is shared by their older brother, Adam. Though, with him away at college, it has become more or less their and *their* room only. His bed is neatly made, waiting to be slept in again, and all the trophies and awards he has gotten in life from sports and academics hang above his bed. Adora has their fair share above their own but not nearly as many as their brother. Glow in the dark stars, stuck up by the pair of siblings, sit on the ceiling and walls, waiting for the darkness to arrive. Meanwhile, Adora cannot wait for Adam to return home.

His fall break should be soon. He'll be back for a week and Adora has been counting down the days. The two have always been close—as close as siblings can be. Despite their two year age gap, others joke they are like twins with how they would do everything together growing up. Not to mention, Adora and Adam share the same birthday. They sure are quite the pair.

Adora slips on their red and yellow striped sweater and faded jeans. The world outside is painted in reds, oranges, and yellows. Even the sky this early in the morning is the same shade as many leaves clinging to trees. The weather will only continue to drop the temperature more and more. Snow and frost will overtake the world in a matter of months.

The SOUL begins to push them out of the room. Adora groans, unable to do much against the invisible force. They exit the room and take a surprising right turn. They stop at their mirror. Adora leaves their dark blonde locks loose, not in the mood to put it up in their usual ponytail. They can see bags under their sky blue eyes, hoping none of their friends notice their lack of sleep.

A voice enters their head: * *It's you!*

Adora scoffs. No shit it's them. Why does this thing have to remind them about that? Thankfully, they are not here for long. They make their way down the stairs, one by one, until they reach the bottom. Inside the kitchen, their mother is cooking breakfast. By the smell hanging in the air, it's bacon and scrambled eggs. They walk further in the room. As Adora passes the fridge, something catches their eye.

Their favorite photo, one of the whole family. Their father, Randor, is in the center of the frame. His blonde hair stops short of his chin and light blue eyes look over a pair of glasses. Besides him, Marlena is in a fit of laughter. Why? Randor has both his children in his arms. Adora, age eight, in one, eyes shut, tears pricking at the edges, as they laugh their ass off. Adam, age ten, is in the other. One dark blue eye is shut while the other looks up at his father. Even back then, their brother's hair, the same shade as their own, is tied into a small ponytail. More reasons to call the two twins.

"Adora, are you feeling alright?" Marlena asks.

Adora jumps. So lost in thought, they forgot they were not alone here.

“What do you mean, Ma?” Adora asks.

Marlena pushes the eggs on the frying pan, knowing how their child likes them. Brown and dry. She keeps a close eye on the bacon as she turns her attention towards Adora. “I heard you shuffling around in your room last night. Actually, I have heard you a few times. And it’s not like you to sleep in like this morning. Is everything okay?”

Adora opens their mouth, wanting to answer, but words lodge in their throat. They can see the SOUL, something their mother cannot, flicks back and forth with a decision. Yes or no. Adora struggles to push the SOUL to ‘no’. An act of defiance and wanting someone to know their turmoil. However, they lose.

* *Yes.*

Damn it! Adora thinks to themself.

Their mother blinks. “Are you sure?”

There is no turning back now. “Yeah. I am just...stressed with school. And with Adam coming home soon, I can’t sleep either. I miss him so I can’t wait to see him again.”

“That is understandable. You know if you need anything, if you want to stay home from school to decompress, you can always ask me.”

“Thanks, Ma.”

Marlena smiles, reminding Adora no matter what, they have their mother on their side.

“Sit down now, dear. We have to eat before we go to school.”

Adora settles down at the table. It takes no time at all for their mother to place a piping hot plate down in front of them. Marlena sits in the chair beside them, eating her own plate. Both mother and child will be seeing each other at school today, after all the

older woman being the younger children's in town teacher. Meanwhile, they won't see their father until later tonight. He owns a flower shop on the other side of town. It opens early in the day and doesn't close until around dinner.

They chatter a bit, mostly about what will be happening later tonight for dinner and what not. It helps get Adora's mind off of what's inside of them, which has decided to take a break. Once their plates are clean, they throw their dishes into the dishwasher and head out to spend the day at school. As the car rumbles to life, heat softly blowing through the vents, Adora rests their head against the window.

The drive to school is not terribly long. In a small town such as Etheria, Adora knows them all and they all know them. So many of their classmates they have been with since pre-k or even *diapers.* Still, somehow, they don't know how to tell anyone, such as their family, about what is inside of them. Would anyone even believe them? Would they think they are crazy and making things up? Word moves fast in such a small town. Anyone they don't want to know about the SOUL will find out about it by the end of the day.

The car sputters to a halt. The single story, brick walled school stares back at Adora.

"Now, you have a good day, dear. Try not to get in too much trouble," she gives a small wink.

Adora feels a wave of embarrassment wash over them. Word sure has gotten out about them spending their day with Catra and failing to bring back chalk that one time. At least, though, it is making their parents happy they are making more friends. So what if some trouble goes along with it. Their mother leans forward, placing a peck on their child's temple. The two part their ways down separate hallways.

Their classroom is small, only about twelve students in total. Adora recognizes two the most. One, on the far upper corner of

the rows is Scorpia. A scorpion monster, claws for hands and a venomous stinger behind her. Her snow white hair is shaved at the sides and she definitely is the tallest person in this room, next to Huntara. When Scorpia spots Adora, she gives a wave with one of her claws, dark eyes bright.

The other person sits behind Adora. Local bully slowly turning into an asshole with a heart of gold (though there still can be ice around her heart). Catra. The magicat monster has her feet up on the desk, body pushing the chair back. Her brown tail moves around behind her and ears twitch at the nose of footsteps. She lifts her head up, revealing cyan and amber eyes.

"Can't believe I beat you here again, Blondie," Catra teases.

Adora drops their bag on the side of the desk. "So? Had a late start s'all." They sit down on their chair.

"We still good to go into the Dark World today." Catra lets the chair drop, allowing her to lean forward. She lowers her voice into a whisper so only Adora can hear. "I think I found another area!"

"You did?"

"Yeah! In the flower store. The one your old man owns."

Adora raises an eyebrow. "Okay, **A** , how do you know this and, **B** , how are we going to get there without my dad asking me what the hell I am doing?"

" **A** , I just do. I saw something weird when I was walking around last night. And **B** , leave that to me!"

Adora groans. Both of those answers do little to settle the bundle of nerves forming in their stomach. How the hell are they going to not alert their father to what they are doing? Lying to him definitely does not sit right with them.

Though, who knows if the SOUL does…

There is a sudden loud bang, startling everyone in the classroom. Up at the front desk, Huntara has slammed her hands against the wooden top, knocking over her glass full of pens and pencils. Despite the cooling weather, the older woman seems to be allergic to sleeves. Part of it stems from the fact she will drop anything and everything to show off her scars on her purple skin and recount the tales on how she got them.

“Alright!” Huntara shouts. She snatches a bit of chalk and begins writing on the board behind her. “Pop quiz time. I’m going to see how well you all remember your fractions.”

This earns a groan from everyone in the classroom. Huntara looks over her shoulder, grinning from ear to ear.

“Definitely can’t wait for school to be over,” Catra sighs.

“Ditto.” Adora replies.

They don't like the idea of sneaking into their father's shop. There isn't much of an option really. If they all went into the store, said 'hi' to Randor, and then disappeared, that is no good. It would give their father a heart attack and a half. So, sneaking in it is.

And...when prompted on what to do, walk in or sneak, the SOUL figured to do the latter anyway.

Adora brings Catra and Scorpia around the back, hoping their father isn't looking out the window right now. The scorpion monster has recently discovered the Dark World and has been a valuable ally. There also is the fact both she and Catra refuse to admit they like each other. Everyone in Etheria and in the Dark World can see it, however. Hell, Adora is pretty sure the SOUL knows it.

They stop at the back door. Adora lifts their head enough for their eyes to peer into the back door window. No life other than plants are inside the room. No signs of their father. They pull themself back into a squatting position.

"Okay, my dad isn't around. What the hell do you have planned?" Adora asks, raising an eyebrow at the magicat. "Please don't tell me it means breaking my dad's window."

"Don't worry your pretty little blonde hair off." Catra digs into her jacket pocket before pulling out some lint and a lock pic. Another one of Adora's eyebrows go up.

"You know I have keys…"

Catra snorts. "This is more fun. Move aside."

**Let her.*

Adora's body moves without their command. They growl under their breath. They had hoped no one would hear the noise of frustration but Catra pauses for a moment. Dual colored eyes confused. Adora says nothing before turning their head around. Whatever their friend might be thinking, she doesn't say anything. Instead, the sound of metal clicking together fills the air. In a matter of moments, the door opens up. The trio enters the dark room. Catra shuts the door and locks it.

"So, where is it?" Scorpia asks in a whisper.

Catra looks around, the only one in the room with vision that works well in the dark. Adora can see the ears on top of her head perk up. She points at an open closet door. Adora recognizes it, where their father stores fertilizer. They know it like the back of their hand not only from all the help they'd give to their father, but from all the times they and their brother would play hide-n'-seek.

Now, however, Adora cannot see anything. Only pitch blackness—darker than the world around them—sits in front of them. The temperature in the direct area of the frame has dip below freezing. Adora can feel the goosebumps forming on their skin and their breath crystallizing in front of them. The Dark World is feet away from them.

“You guys ready?” Catra asks.

Adora and Scorpia nod. Catra doesn’t miss a beat and jumps head first into the darkness. The other two quickly follow behind. Adora feels the clothes around them change, taking a new form. No longer do they have their sweater on. Rather, armor now rests on their shoulders and chest. A trusted sword (sometimes a shield as well) sits on their hip. Around their neck is a piece of fabric, like a small cape that will blow in the wind. While their sweater is red and yellow, this has stripes as gold as the sun, as white as snow, as purple as amethyst, and as black as the night sky.

Hard earth meets the trio. Adora rises first, looking around the new area. They have ended up in a forest. Lush trees reach for the sky. Leaves, vibrant with every color in the rainbow, cover the top of the world in a thick canopy. Only silvers of light pours through and land on a stony path. On the ground, lush bushes and flowers oozing strong smells are everywhere. Everything around them looks like something out of their father’s dream garden.

Catra and Scorpia slowly get to their feet, each having changed into different clothing as well. The magicat reflects her more tough personality. A vest (which surprisingly doesn’t have spikes), ripped up pants, boots, and spiked wrist and arm bands. While Adora has their sword, Catra has an axe. Scorpia, on the other hand, has a long, gorgeous dress, the same shade as her hair, flowing down her strong frame. There even is a small, shining crown resting on her forehead. Unlike her friends, she has no weapons and relies solely on electrical magic.

Rustling catches Adora’s attention. They have just enough time to spin around before soft lilac feathers surround them. Warm arms wrap around their body and a new flowery scent fills their nose. Moments later, lips lock against theirs. For a moment, any fear, doubt, or worry Adora has faded from existence.

“Glimmer!” the now knight shouts with glee.

“I missed you!” Glimmer replies, sparkles growing in her lilac eyes. The Darkner can fool others for a Lightner. Human looking. A foot smaller than Adora and dawning pink and purple hair as soft as clouds. She has her own lavender dress on with an icy blue cape behind her that shimmers in the light. Like Scorpia, she relies on her own magic but has a trusted staff with her. The only thing that really sticks out are her large, feathery wings jutting behind her back.

“God, gross. It’s only been a day. Get a room you two!” Catra huffs.

Glimmer flips her off.

Behind the angel, is one of Adora’s dearest and best friends. Bow. Another Darkner. Like Glimmer, he could easily be mistaken otherwise. He has a simple, cropped tunic and slacks. Like Adora, he has a fabric resting around his shoulders, though longer—going down to his stomach. His fabric is colored blue, pink, and white. What makes Bow stand out, besides his archery equipment behind his back, is his pointed ears. Adora gives him a tight hug.

“Are you ready to close another fountain?”

Truthfully? Yes. Yes they are. Coming to the Dark World has always been a blast. Ever since they accidentally came in here and met Glimmer and Bow. After all, they have fallen for the angel. They never thought much about love and romance. Glimmer’s magic might be light based but Adora wonders if she secretly has a ‘falling in love’ spell with how head over heels they feel about her. And what about Bow? He’s like another brother. Or becoming closer to Scorpia, their lifelong neighbour? And Adora has to admit, Catra has learned from mistakes and become a better person here. What’s there not to love?

They open their mouth to agree, however the words they want to say, a simple ‘yes’, lodge in their throat. Something else comes out.

**Hell yeah I am!*

Adora resists the urge to twist their lips into a frown. Seeing the glee on their friends' faces, they don't need anyone to worry. Before venturing deeper into the forest, everyone checks their things. Full health all around. Items are stocked up but there is room left for more with the money they have. Then the final thing, figuring out who will be with Adora first. Whenever a Darkner wants to fight, only three can fight at once. Adora *always* leads (all because of the SOUL). Everyone else swaps around.

For now, Catra and Glimmer will accompany Adora while Bow and Scorpia shall cheer from the sidelines. Everyone will get their turn to ACT or show off their magic (or in rare cases, be on the offensive). With everyone ready, the group marches forward.

The further they go in, the more the new Dark World morphs into something new. Tree trunks become thicker. Thorns poke out of bushes, waiting for others to curiously stick their fingers out. At one point, Adora has to grab Catra by the collar of her vest and pull her away from a bundle of bushes. It is not until after several minutes of walking do they have an encounter.

Adora sees a sapling in the middle of the path. Everyone stops in their tracks, turning their sights onto their leader. The knight steps forward and reaches a hand out. In the blink of an eye, the bark splits into jagged lines and chops down on their fingers. They yelp in pain, jerking back their arm as a battle kicks into high gear. The SOUL pops out of Adora's body, hovering in the air. They still wonder if anyone questions what the hell this red heart thing is.

"Finally, some action!" Catra gleefully shouts. She whips out her axe and rests it on her shoulder.

"Catra, remember to take it easy," Bow sighs from the sidelines.

"You'll do great out there, Wildcat!" Scorpia shouts.

Out of the corner of their eye, Adora see's Catra's face turn a shade of red. They look back at the enemy in front of them. The

sapling has suddenly grown to be as tall as Scorpia. Their branches twist into claws and the silt in the bark is full of threatening teeth. Growls fill the air as they stare down the trio. Time for the SOUL to figure out what to do.

Thankfully, it decides to ACT. Actually, most of the time it does that after the whole speech on kindness. Adora agrees with the sentiment, that there can be good in anyone and fighting only has to be a last resort. However, once in a while the unforeseen entity has a wicked side, seeing how much they can beat up innocent things. It selects the option of watering, an ACT by all three.

Out of thin air, the trio gains either a hose or watering can. Adora, Catra, and Glimmer blast the sapling with water. Branches and the top of the tree's head suddenly grow pale buds. Now it's time to be on the defensive. The SOUL begins to move around as the tree shoots out hundreds of thorns. Some nip the red heart, sending shock waves of pain throughout the knight's body. They wince, hearing Catra doing the same. Another thing that sucks about this stupid thing. The others will get hurt and there isn't much Adora can do.

Another chance to ACT. For water is sprayed and the buds grow. Whatever lies inside *begging* to burst towards freedom. Another flurry of thorns, this time the SOUL manages to dodge everything. One more ACT. One more river. This time, the buds open, revealing brilliant flowers, almost glowing in the light. The angered expression on the tree's face twists to a happy one. Words still cannot be formed but by the sounds it is now making, Adora assumes it is please.

The spare is easy and done in the blink of an eye. Not too bad for their first encounter of the day. Adora sighs as the SOUL returns to them, waiting to spring forth and battle or choice commands they do not want.

"Are you guys okay?" Bow asks upon walking up to the trio.

"Just a scratch," Adora says.

“Yeah!” Catra puffs out her chest. “Nothing that I can’t handle. No silly tree can knock me down!”

Scorpia beams. “Heck yeah! You did amazing, Wildcat!”

Catra deflates, the blush on her face grows. Hell, it seems to reach her ears. Glimmer and Adora snicker at the sight, loving to have ammo to tease the magicat with. Catra looks away from Scorpia, taking a moment to glare at the knight and angel, before leading the charge forward.

“We still have a long way to go before finding the fountain. Let’s get a move on!”

“She can’t outrun her feelings forever,” Bow whispers, joining in on the fun.

“We still betting on when they’ll get together?” Glimmer replies. “Hopefully soon. I am getting low on money.”

Adora chuckles, secretly hoping that they’ll win. After all, they have more of a chance to try and get Catra and Scorpia together. “Let’s go before she gets in trouble.”

They nudge their friends along, quickly catching up to the magicat. Catra is standing off to the side, rocking on her heels. Once everyone is back together, they all fall back in line, Adora at the helm. More enemies pop out, more sparing. Sometimes it is Adora, Catra, and Glimmer, other times Scorpia or Bow switch in to flex their own muscles. Each time the SOUL is hit, Adora can’t help but feel their own soul twist hearing their friends cry out in pain.

There is one battle that gets under their skin. A tough looking venus fly trap enemy (its head is an actual bear trap). It snaps at them, spit burning everyone’s skin. After trying to figure out how to spare the thing, the monster attacks once more. This time, the acid-like spit hits the SOUL dead on. Adora feels it burning their skin but also watches Bow and Glimmer collapse to the ground,

too tired to fight anymore. Catra and Scorpia are useless on the sideline. There is no tag teaming here.

Shit, shit, shit! Adora shouts at themself. Part of them truly wants to smack the fuck out of this monster for hurting their friends. For being so hard to spare. They know that their girlfriend and friend will be fine. Shaken and needing some healing but overall just fine. They'll still feel bad for letting the two go down. These do not help but one thing sends shivers down their spine.

When all three in battle loses all their strength, when they no longer can lift their heads up, the SOUL breaks in two before shattering into a million pieces. This has happened several times. Each one, each time it no longer is whole, Adora can *feel* it. Feel sheer pain, the worst pain they have ever felt, courses through their body. Every part of them—muscles, bones, *molecules* —is on red hot fire. The whole world turns into a cold blackness and they cannot see any part of their body.

Adora wonders if that is what death feels like. Whatever the case, they hate it. Each time they 'die' a strange voice will whisper something along the lines of ' *This is not your fate! Please, don't give up'* or ' *We need you here, please stay!'* Adora never wants to give up. For once, the SOUL and them agree. Never have they given up.

Each time they 'die', they are thrown back to what they have dubbed a 'save point'. Most of their life, Adora has been able to see a sparkling light. Like a star has been pulled straight out of the night sky and down to the ground. Only they see it, however. Up until recently, they did not think much of it and tried to ignore it. Now they know what it is. But they aren't about to let that happen tonight.

Adora makes a stand. They feel the sweat dripping down the side of their face. Shaking breaths escape them, the thought of 'dying' wraps a thorn cover tendrils around their heart. They try another ACT, throwing a random object from their pocket. They don't even check to see what they have thrown, only praying it works. The

item soars through the air, doing several flips, before landing at the trigger pad of the plant's mouth. It snaps shut, metal clicking together, and becomes pleased. Adora sighs a breath of relief as they finally spare the monster. It scampers off into the brush, never to be seen again.

"Ugh," Glimmer groans, finally able to rise to her feet. "That one was rough."

"Are you guys okay?" Scorpia asks, helping Bow and Glimmer up. Adora finds themself tired. As everyone else gets *to* their feet, they fall *from* their feet.

"I think we need a break for a sec," they state. Adora digs around their bag and begins to chow down on some food. The moment they swallow, they can feel their battered body healing.

"Yo, Adora. Are you okay?" Catra asks.

"What do you mean?"

Catra's ears fall flat on her head. "I saw you fighting after Sparkles and Arrow Head went down. You look really pale. Still do."

Adora gulps. They still are getting used to kindness from the magicat. Catra even seems unsure about doing so, scratching the side of her face. The knight is not happy that they are worrying someone.

"It was a tough battle, that's all."

"Why don't you ever let one of us switch off with you? So you can take a break." Bow asks.

Adora shakes their head. As long as the SOUL is inside of them, there is no break. They take a bite of their food, finishing it off. "I'm fine. I don't need a break. I'm the leader, aren't I?" They dust themself off.

Glimmer walks up to them, placing a hand on their shoulder. “Are you sure, love? You know you can tell us anything.”

I know…

* *Don’t worry about it.*

“Okay.” Glimmer stands up on the tips of her toes. Warm lips brush against their cheek, near some long ago scars from when they and Catra were bitter enemies. “If anything ever is bothering you, just let us know.”

“Thanks.” Adora replies. They return the kiss on top of her head. “Let’s go close that fountain. We have to be close.”

The fountain shoots gallons upon gallons of black liquid upward. It meets the same colored sky, there is no way to see where it ends. If this continues, the sky soon will crack and splinter from the beating it is receiving. Then, it’ll burst through and spill out into the world above it. *Etheria* to be exact. They cannot allow that to happen. The SOUL will be able to shut it and seal it off for good. Any Darkners who want can come live in Brightmoon, Glimmer’s and Bow’s home. And by stopping the flow, they’ll also be able to free the princess, usually trapped by a monster. Just like what happened with Frosta.

But that is the problem. Closing the fountain is not that simple. Adora looks around, seeking what usually tries to stop them from their quest. It does not take long for them to find it. Or, rather, for it to find them.

There is a low rumble. Adora looks down at their feet, seeing dirt and pebbles dancing around. Suddenly, thick, leafy vines shoot upward. Adora stumbles back, colliding with Scopria in their escape. The scorpion monster catches them and all eyes turn upward at the vines. They twist and turn as they take shape. The thick plant wraps around a large tree monster, pressing so hard

into the bark it squeezes the hard, outer shell. It's arms, legs, body, and neck all have a wrapping around them.

The monster does not seem conscious. Their body moves in tune with the vines,which reach upward. They connect to a hand of a larger monster, it's body totally made up of the same thick, leafy vines. The shape is humanoid with a wicked grin and cold eyes that glow. The larger creature laughs a harsh laugh as it moves the smaller one around, forcing it to fire off attacks. Adora, Scorpia, and Catra all bolt out of the way as they are forced into a battle.

"What the heck is that?" Scorpia gasps.

Catra spins her axe in her hand. Adora can see the fear edged into her face. This is the largest (and creepiest) thing everyone has ever seen. "That thing looks like it is controlling the other one. It's like-"

"A puppet and puppeteer." Adora feels their body go cold as ice. For a moment, as they stare at the final battle of this area, they do not see a monster. Rather, the tree morphs into themself. Vines turn into thin red lines which connect to the SOUL, larger than the one inside of them. Adora swears they can see a shadowy hand hovering over the SOUL, giving out the commands they have to listen to.

Adora is frozen in place, breath caught in their throat. The SOUL begins to move, attempting to dodge the flurry of vines. It fails and is hit at the center, causing pain for all three fighting. Catra spins on her heels, ears so tight at attention it's a surprise they aren't sprained, and tail puffed fully.

"ADORA! SNAP OUT OF IT!" she shouts. "WE NEED TO TAKE THIS BASTARD OUT!"

Adora shakes their head, though fog lingers. They look at their friends. Catra stares at them with a fury in her eyes. Not of anger (though there is a slight hint of it) but of worry about what is

going on. Scorpia's gaze is softer but ready for the challenge ahead. Off to the sideline, Bow and Glimmer somehow have materialized posters reading ` *You Got This'* and ` *We believe in you!'*

Adora feels a wave of determination wash over them. Right. There isn't time to freeze up. They grab their sword, it shining in an unseen light. Time to make a stand against this creature. This is one of the handful of battles where sparing is hard. The best way to stop this thing is beat it until it gives. Especially with it having a hostage. Freeing them *must* come first.

"Be careful of what it has. We don't want to harm them!" Adora shouts.

"No shit," Catra huffs. "Let's make some salad out of this fucker."

The battle goes back and forth. More attacks of vines, striking at the SOUL. The trio either attacks, chipping away at the monster's health or try to figure out an ACT that works. Nothing seems to work much. The vine monster remains standing and sometimes will use it's hostage as a shield. If the trio can, they'll stop their attack. It doesn't work all the time, however.

Adora grits their teeth as they try to figure out what to do. Even the SOUL seems to be at a loss on what to do. Catra and Scorpia are low on health. At least giving them things to heal is doing something. Adora smiles, knowing they can help their friends.

They should be paying attention.

The monster suddenly launches another attack. Different from before. Vines shoot forward but twist into fingers. No, a *hand.* Before anyone can react, it grabs Adora, nearly crushing their rib cage from their might. All the air is squeezed out of their lungs as they are pulled back, towards the creature. Adora hears their friends shouting and cursing, demanding for the knight's return. But it is quickly drowned out by menacing laughter.

Adora manages to pull out an arm, though their left. Their right, the one gripping their sword, remains pinned to their side. They are brought to the face of the vine creature, wondering if they are about to be eaten whole.

"Let g-go of th-them!" Adora wheezes. "S-Stop controlling th-them!" They wonder who they are saying this too.

The monster laughs harder. So loud it nearly burst Adora's ear rums. "I don't think so."

"B-B-Bastard! I-I won't let y-you keep d-doing that!"

Another laugh. Adora is brought closer. *Yeah, I am about to get eaten, aren't I?* They think.

But that is not what happens.

"Since when did you have a say on who's in control?"

Those words cut into them like a hot knife. Their heart stops in their chest and any fight in their body fades away. Does this thing know about the SOUL? But their own battle with being a puppet. After all, they have strings around an innocent being, could they recognize it occurring to someone else?

Adora barely registers the monster throwing their arm back. In a split second, they are flung through the air. Gravity wraps around them and pulls them down to the hard ground. Adora cannot break their fall at all. They bounce, rocks slicing through their skin and denting their armor, and bruising their body. As they slow to a halt, they skid several feet, leaving a line behind, before finally coming to a stop.

"Holy shit, Adora!" they hear Catra say in the distance. "Are you okay?!?"

"Adora!" Glimmer's cries pierce their ears, twisting their heart tight. There is nothing she can do to help them, not while this battle is still raging on. And there is nothing *Adora* can do at the

moment. At some point during when Adora was restrained, the SOUL must have taken a hit. Coupled with their own fall, the knight can no longer stand. They are *down* and either must wait for their health to return to them. Neither Catra nor Scorpia are skilled in healing magic and items they carried have been almost totally used.

All Adora can do is lie helpless on the ground and watch the battle play out before their eyes.

Catra says something to Scorpia, who seems hesitant. The scorpion monster is unsure of whatever the magicat is telling her. But with another look at the monster before them, Scorpia nods in agreement. The SOUL seems to like whatever is being cooked up as they allowed for the ACT.

Scorpia uses the venom from her tail, spraying it on the edge of Catra's axe. Satisfied, the magicat turns her sights back at the monster, who has begun to laugh once more. Even from this distance, Adora can hear it loud and clear. As if they ever left their grasp. Catra swings her arm in a circle, gaining momentum before throwing her axe as hard and far as possible. It makes its mark.

The sharp edge embeds itself in the neck of the beast. By the looks of it, it's roughly in the same area as one's jugular. The monster rears back in pain, shouting at the top of their lungs. The vines that wrap around the other monster unfurl. Scorpia is quick on her feet and catches them before they collide with the ground. She jumps back just in the nick of time as the monster hovering above crashes to the earth.

They won.

The SOUL shoots back into their body. With the battle over, Adora finds their legs and pushes themself up into a sitting position. Their body remains beaten and achy. The light only they can see would heal them in an instant. That, or-

“Adora! Let me heal you!” Glimmer skids on her knees the rest of the way to her partner. Besides her light magic, she knows a thing or two about healing. Her hands and eyes light up a soft white blue. Lips move and words Adora cannot understand come out. A ball of light, in the same color as her eyes and hands, comes to life. The knight reaches out for it. The moment their fingers touch the cool orb of light, their body feels a hundred times lighter.

Skin zips up wounds, bruises fade away. Only now do they realize a rib had been broken, feeling it fuse back together. Adora sighs a breath of relief as the pain disappears.

Two pairs of arms suddenly wrap around their body. Glimmer and Bow nearly push them back onto the ground.

“You scared the shit out of us!” Glimmer shouts.

“I don’t know how you survived that without getting even more injured,” Bow adds.

* *I got lucky.*

“Damn straight you did.” Catra states. She and Scorpia have joined the pair, the other monster still in Scorpia’s arms.

“Hey, are they okay?” Adora asks, wanting to change the subject.

They get an answer almost right away. The monster in Scorpia’s arms begins to move, bark falling apart. Scorpia lets go of them, placing them down on the ground. Everyone gives them room. As the bark slips off, it reveals a young looking woman. Blonde hair, paler than Adora’s, is loose and hazel eyes are bright. Freckles dot her face and tanned shoulders. Like Bow, she has pointed ears. Green markings, the shape of vines with leaves, wrap around her arms. She groans before looking up at the group around her.

“Oh, hello,” she says.

“What the fuck?” Catra blurts out first. “Care to explain what’s going on?!?”

“Catra, give her some breathing room,” Glimmer says.

The Darker sits up, rubbing her neck. She looks around, eyes landing right on the fallen monster. “Are you the ones who defeated that thing?”

“Yes we are!” Scorpia chirps.

“Well, I owe you my thanks. I was minding my own business when that thing came at me. I used some of my magic to make a shell around me to protect me but the damn thing still knocked me out.”

“Are you okay?” Adora asks. “What’s your name?”

“I’m sure but I will be okay. I’m Perfuma, a princess. Who are you guys?”

“We are here to help out and close that stupid dark fountain causing all these issues. And,” Catra places a hand on top of Adora's head. “This wonderful person here is the one who is going to do that. Got a special ability to do so!”

“Well, thank you.” Perfuma says. Scorpia helps her to her feet.

“C’mon. Let’s go close that damn thing.”

Adora slowly gets to their feet. Alongside Bow and Glimmer, they walk up to the flowing fountain. So close to it now, they can feel the chill in the air. Hairs stand on the back of their neck and they have goosebumps all over their body. With a breath, the SOUL exits their body. The fountain freezes, like it has turned into ice. A blinding light covers the whole area, basking everyone in warmth, before it fades away. Nothing stands in front of them anymore. The fountain is shut, forever.

Everyone heads back to Brightmoon, excitement in the air. Perfuma is excited at the thought of seeing a new land and meeting new people. Everyone else is eager to see their other

friends. Despite only being gone for a day, it feels like forever. Even after everything that has gone on, Adora has a skip in their step.

Brightmoon is a large place, colorful, and full of life. Shops are busy and many monsters are talking. When they see the group, everyone waves, smiles plastered on their faces. Perfuma is wide-eyed as she takes in all the sights. When everyone gets to the center of town, a familiar face pops out of nowhere.

"You guys had fun without me!" Frosta shouts on the top of their lungs.

"Hey, hey, hey!" Catra shouts. She wraps an arm around Frosta's neck, pulling her close before rubbing a first against her dark blue hair. "What about you, Shrimp? You have all these people to pull pranks on without me!"

Frosta laughs. The smaller Darkner, a princess in her own right, wears winter clothing. Ice shards are all over her hair and her skin is always cold to the touch. She was the first princess the group rescued. Somehow, she and Catra have formed a hell of a sisterly bond with one another.

Catra lets go of her. "You still gotta tell me all of those tricks! I need to do them in my own world."

"Come and visit more and I will tell you. Deal?" Frosta sticks out her hand. Catra takes it, about to shake to seal the deal. However, her furred hand turns to a sheet of ice.

"HEY!" the magicat shouts before Frosta runs off, in hysterics. Catra is hot on her heels.

"Those two sure never get boring, huh?" Glimmer chuckles.

"Yeah…" Adora's mind wanders. With the calm around them, their brain has decided to be the opposite of that. The monster from before refuses to dissipate from their mind. The words it said ' *Since when did you have a say on who's in control?* ' ring in their

ears, haunting them to their core. The truth is, they don't know if they ever had a say. The SOUL inside of them...will it ever give them a chance?

Glimmer nudges them. "Are you okay? You look a little pale."

"Yeah. I'm fine." They rub the back of their neck. "That battle just took a lot out of me."

"It sure was rough. Do you want to go rest in the castle?" Glimmer takes their hand, rubbing a thumb against the back.

* *No. I'm good.*

I fuckin' hate you.

"Well, let's go get a bite to eat then!"

" *Getoffgetoffgetoff!"* Adora rapidly says. They have had enough of being crushed, of having the air being pushed out of their lungs. The exit out of the Dark World is far from graceful. Scorpia and Catra both rest on top of them, all their weight crushing their spine. The two roll off of them, allowing them to breathe again.

"Sorry!" Scorpia shouts. She helps them to her feet. Once Adora is stable, she turns to Catra. The magicat does not take it right away. A blush forms on both their faces before Catra is lifted up. Just as she is settling her body into the upright position, the light in the room blinds everyone.

"Kids?!?" a rough and low voice says.

Adora spins on their heels. Standing in the door frame is their father. They stand almost as tall as Scorpia and the two have the same type of build. He shaved his face several days ago but dark stubble is poking its head out from his chin. His short, dark blonde hair has some dirt and a couple leaves resting inside.

“H-Hiya, Dad!” Adora blurts out. Their heart pounds in their chest, palms covered in sweat. “What’s up?”

“I can ask the same about you three. What are you guys doing here?”

“I, uh, just saying ‘hi’. Yeah! Can’t your child stop by and see their father?”

“You sure have a unique way of doing it.” Randor places a potted plant on a nearby table. “I was about to close up shop and head home. Catra, Scorpia, do you two want to come over for dinner?”

“Thanks but no thanks, Mr. Randor! I gotta go do some homework,” Catra says, a blatant lie.

“I have to go also before my moms worry. Maybe next time,” Scorpia says.

The two bolt out, leaving Adora behind with their father. Randor walks over to his child and places a hand on their shoulder. “I am happy you are making more friends and getting out more. Though, maybe be a little more careful. You three might get into serious trouble if you are not.”

Adora chuckles a little. They already have been through that plenty of times in the Dark World. “Don’t worry, Dad. We’ll be careful. I promise.”

“Thank you, honey. Do you want to walk home? I just need to wrap up a few more things. Do you mind helping your old man?”

“Not at all.”

The last of the crickets sing their song. Winter soon will freeze them all until the spring warmth thaws them. In a small town such as Etheria, away from the big city and its dazzling lights, millions of stars hang above the dark sky. With no moon, even more shine. They all watch Adora through the crack in their

curtain. The glow in the dark stars and moon plastered on the wall join their real life siblings in the ‘show’ playing out in front of them.

Another restless night.

Adora holds the SOUL tight in their hand, gasping from their struggling. With their other arm, they wipe the sweat from their brow. Tears prick at the side of their eyes, some rolling down their cheeks. In the dark light, the SOUL glows. The light traces Adora’s outline in a soft, red glow. Their mind is on high alert.

‘ *Since when did you have a say on who’s in control?’*

Adora looks at the busted up birdcage. They throw the SOUL into it. It hits the rusted side with force, nearly knocking the metal cage over. Adora is quick to snap the door shut, tightening the lock as far as possible. The SOUL moves around the cage, trying to free itself again. Adora takes the birdcage in their hands and brings it close to their face.

‘ *Since when did you have a say on who’s in control?*

“Stay the *fuck* in there! For *once* in your damn life!” Adora growls at the SOUL, hoping it will listen to them. Though something deep inside of them tells them when the sun digs itself out of the horizon, control will no longer be in their grasp.

Ocean Avenue

Chapter Notes

> eh not much to say other than kind of death tw? youll know what i mean but enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next morning, Adora wakes before their alarm. Before their mother can come and collect them. They flick the knob at the top, ensuring it never goes off until they say so. Adora, however, remains lying on their side, covers up to their chin. Their eyes stare at their older brother's bed, heart aching to see him again. He always knows how to bring a smile to their face when they need it the most. When Adora doesn't want to talk to their mother or father about the things bothering them, he is always there to listen to them.

They have to survive a little while longer.

Adora rolls onto their stomach. They prop themself up onto one arm, lifting themself slightly off the bed. With their other hand, they check for the SOUL. Sure enough, it is back inside of them. They really need to invest in a padlock or two. Adora was able to stay awake for a while, free from the strings of the SOUL, but sleep gripped them. Guess it took advantage of their unconsciousness. *Damn all.*

They growl under their breath, wondering what the hell the SOUL has planned for today. Adora knows they need this accursed thing. How else will they stop the flow of the fountains? How else can they protect everyone they love both here and in the Dark World and every other innocent life? A burden they *never* asked for, one they wish they could have a say in. If only there was another way, one where *they* are in control.

Maybe that is only a reality in their dreams.

With a sigh, they roll out of bed. Rinse and repeat yesterday. Slip on their sweater, make themself look presentable, and try to hide the weariness from everyone around them. In some feeble attempt to mask the growing cracks, they splash cold water from the tap onto their face. Adora places their hands on the smooth countertop and takes a good look at themself. Nothing has changed from the day before. Which, at least, they don't look worse.

Adora turns their sight to the toilet. They still wonder what the hell came over the SOUL that one time made them flush it over and over again until their mother knocked on the door and, rightfully concerned, asked ` *Adora, what the hell are you doing in there?'* They had no idea how to answer, the SOUL leaving them up to their own deceives. In the end, Adora told their mother they zoned out and didn't realize what they were doing.

Thankfully, the SOUL no longer seems interested in messing with the water bill. It can cause mischief in other ways.

It pushes them out of the bathroom. At first, Adora does little to stop it. What can they do after all? The SOUL can be more stubborn than Glimmer. They walk into the kitchen, their mother still upstairs. Adora can hear her shuffling around, preparing to join her child. While waiting to see their mother, the SOUL investigates everything.

The fridge, which has been stocked only a few days ago, the table with four chairs and placemats, under every cushion in the living room. Every inch of the house Adora knows like the back of their hand, they are forced to search.

I don't know what you are looking for, they think to themself. *All you're gonna find is some spare change at most.*

They begin to think the SOUL has had enough of poking around their home, into their private life, when it brings them back to their fridge. Adora raises an eyebrow, wondering what they are

doing back here. The SOUL already checked this and breakfast will be soon. What does it want?

* *Take the pie.*

What?!?

Adora shakes as they fight back the invisible strings around their wrist. There are only a couple slices of their mother's famous pie left. Cinnamon butterscotch. They grab their moving arm with their other hand but it does little to stop fingers wrapping around a dish. First off, why on earth would they have pie first thing in the morning? Even with a sweet tooth like theirs, they know their mother won't be pleased to see this for their breakfast. Secondly, and more importantly, ***fuck*** the SOUL.

Adora's nails dig into their sweater, pressing hard against their skin. But the fight never was in their favor. Their limbs all move without their command, no matter how hard they scream internally. The only thing they can do is grit their teeth together. Even *that,* however, does not last long. Hand shake as the fork stabs the soft, baked sweet, before lifting it near their mouth. There is no use in fighting any longer. They can't waste all their energy before the day even starts.

They relent, letting themself eat the pie. Normally the beloved sweet is heaven to their taste buds. Like a symphony is playing inside their mouth. This time, however, nothing sparks inside. They only feel the coldness from being inside the fridge and the bitterness of regret. How can the SOUL ruin something they always have loved? The urge to rip it straight out of their chest right now grows.

Footsteps on creaking boards pull them out of their thoughts. Their mother appears from around the corner, a hand over her mouth as she yawns.

"'Moring, A-" she pauses for a moment, dark eyes widening with surprise. "'Dora, why are you eating pie this early?"

Fuck.

**I was hungry.*

"I can see that. Are you sure you are feeling okay, honey?" Marlena steps forward. A soft hand is placed on Adora's forehead. "You haven't been acting like yourself lately. Waking up in the middle of the night, doing this, and your father told me he found you and your friends at the flower shop yesterday He still doesn't know why you didn't just go through the front door. I still wonder why you skipped class that one day, over chalk!"

Adora opens their mouth, wishing to tell their mother everything. But words lodge halfway there. Not because of the SOUL, but because of themself. Could they possibly tell their mother what's going on? She'll worry—a lot. Do they really want that? Marlena will and has dropped everything for the sake of her children. Randor as well. Do they really need that burden that something is *controlling* their youngest against their will? What would they even think about something like that!

Their mother's fingers brush against the side of their face, tucking dark blonde locks behind their ear. Adora sighs before pressing their cheek into their mother's palm. "It's nothing, Ma," they lie. Those words are more bitter than the pie they forced down. "I just have a lot going on. My brain's just been all over the place."

"Do you want to stay at home for a couple days? You are allowed to skip school if you are not up to it."

Missing school means quite possibly missing going into the Dark World. Missing being with their friends, with Glimmer. Seeing them all, having fun with them. And they cannot allow the dark fountains swallow two worlds whole.

"I'll be fine, Ma. I promise, okay?"

Marlena wraps her arms around her child, pulling them close. They are nearly the same height, Adora an inch or two taller.

However, the younger of the two buries their face into the crook of their mother’s neck.

“How about I make you some actual breakfast? I don’t think having pie is a great breakfast,” Marlena softly says. She rubs small circles on Adora’s back. “What would you like, honey?”

“Hmm...Pancakes?”

“You want chocolate chips in them?”

Adora’s mouth water’s at the thought. “Yes please.”

They help their mother prep the batter, cracking the eggs and pouring in as much chocolate chips as they can before their mother stops them. In no time at all, the thick liquid turns fluffy and golden brown. Like the morning before, the duo eat together before heading off to school. Adora once more has plans on hanging out with Catra and Scorpia in the Dark World (though obviously they don’t tell the latter bit to their mother). They promise not to be out too late, that they’ll be home either before dark or *just* after it. With the promise in mind, Adora even puts a timer on their watch, they split up for the day.

"You think it's here?" Catra looks around the large room.

"There aren't many other places left in town. No one's here either. Why not check here?" Scorpia replies.

"Good point. Smart."

Out of the corner of their eye, Adora sees Scorpia blushing. The two monsters continue to chatter away about their own memories here. Words turn into static ambiance as Adora investigates the community pool.

There isn't much to it, with how small Etheria is, but it’s still nice. Maybe it’s the nostalgia talking. During the summer, their family would spend time here. Or, as the pool is indoors, even during the

colder months. This is the place they learned to swim and had a number of birthday parties at. Their brother even swam here for swim competitions. Good times. Walls are painted in a way as if they are at the ocean, something they have never seen before.

With renovations going on, the place is empty. Another day, another breaking and entering. All around them, there are signs of the place being worked on. Tarps, tools waiting to be used again, etc. The pool remains full of chlorinated water. Adora sticks their hand into the cool water, moving it around. Small ripples are created, fading away inches from their fingers. Part of them wants to just jump in and enjoy the feeling of the water around them.

There is a whistle. "Yo! Adora!" Catra shouts. "C'mon here!"

Adora jumps to their feet, dashing over to their friends. The monsters stand around the entrance of one of the bathrooms. Instead of the pale, tiled walls, there is nothing but darkness. Those goosebumps return. Excitement fills their chest. Where will it bring them and their friends this time?

"Well, what are we waiting for?" Adora asks, looking back and forth at Catra and Scorpia. "Let's go."

Without another breath wasted, the trio of friends dive straight into the Dark World. Clothing changes. The cool air that always is at the entrance of the two worlds fades. No longer are there goosebumps on their skin. There is a breeze that is comforting and makes them want to lie down and to soak in the feeling. Accompanying this is the sense of warmth—like they are basking in brilliant sun rays. They have stepped out of fall and dove straight into summer.

When they land, it is not on hard ground like last time. Instead, fingers easily dig into what's below them. Something fine and gritty. Something salty enters their nose and mouth. As their fingers continue to figure out where they are, water splashes against their skin. Adora snaps their head up. As far as the eye can see— *further* then they ever have—is nothing but a vast,

sapphire ocean. Miles and miles of it. It goes far beyond the horizon. Adora wonders if there is an end. Soft sand sits below them and white, foaming ends of waves nips at their feet.

Their breath is completely taken out of their lungs. Pure delight and awe fills every inch of their body. They find themself settling onto the wet sand and closing their eyes. The sound of rolling waves and the salt that hangs in the air relaxes their body. Why are they here again? Some type of missions or what have you? Can they stay here forever?

"It's beautiful, isn't it?" Glimmer's voice whispers into their ears. Adora's eyes flutter open and they find their girlfriend sitting right beside them. Bow is nearby, staring out at the ocean. The knight realizes with the Dark World's invisible light source, light is dancing against the water.

"Yeah, it really is." Adora softly says.

They take a look around the beach. To their left and right, just like the water, it goes on for what seems like forever. Catra and Scorpia walk around, leaving their footprints behind, only for the water to erase them. The scorpion monster digs around the sand, collecting colorful shells. Somewhere and somehow, she pulls out a string. Even without fingers, Scorpia swiftly makes a necklace before placing it around Catra.

The magicat freezes up like a statue, tail puffed like a cotton ball and ears lying flat on her head. Dual eyes are wide. Adora cannot hear them from this distance but they have a strong feeling Catra is mumbling a 'thank you'. Scorpia beams.

Adora smiles softly at the sight before turning to face behind them. They are surprised they didn't notice it before. A huge boardwalk, full of Darkners, carnival rides with flashing lights, booths with who knows what, and much more. There even is a chairlift. Adora wonders where one would get onto it. Off in the distance, they see the dark fountain spew out the dark liquid.

“I guess we are going to have to go through all that, huh?” Adora says. They rise to their feet, dusting off the sand from their pants.

“Yup!” Bow chirps. “I’ve never been to a boardwalk before, I can’t wait to see what’s there!”

“I can’t wait to beat your ass at the games.” Glimmer, a wide grin on her face, pokes her friend under his rib cage. “Get ready to lose.”

Adora snorts, wrapping an arm around the angel’s neck. “Don’t count your chickens before they hatch. You still got me to beat!”

“Bring it on!”

They call for Catra and Scorpia, who quickly return to join the rest of the gang. The magicat has tucked the necklace into her shirt, keeping it safe from harm. Together, the five walk up to the boardwalk. Loud music fills Adora’s ears and lights almost blinds them. So many scents assault their nose, they cannot distinguish one from the other. However, it makes their mouth water.

The SOUL begins to tug them in different directions. Guess they are going to be checking out every damn stall. Some of the Darkners simply want to chat, not interested in selling anything. Two even try pulling the group into a debate over if the food at a nearby stand should be called ‘taylor ham’ or a ‘pork roll’.

**Let’s stay out of this one.*

Another rare moment of agreement with the SOUL. They get the hell out of the conversation and move on somewhere else. They go to another stall, this one giving them some food to purchase. Dark funnel cake. The SOUL makes them by it until there is almost no pocket space left. Adora wonders if these things are really worth all the money they just spent.

At a save point, they have a feeling they will find out soon. Adora takes a look over their shoulder, hoping no one is questioning

what they are doing. Once everything is set, it's time to march forward. The dark fountain has grown closer yet still remains out of reach. Before taking their first step, they check their watch. Somehow, it has remained intact, not morphing into some other accessory. If time matches up with their own world, they still should be able to keep their promise to their mother.

Adora guides everyone down the boardwalk, still in awe over all the sights and sounds. They are so distracted they fail to hear the creaking of metal from above until the last moment. The knight sticks out their arm, stopping everyone in their tracks. They look up, eyes catching the blur of a creature before it becomes too close for comfort. Adora stumbles out of the way just as the battle begins.

Two creatures stare back at Adora, Glimmer, and Bow. Their bodies are colorful, sticky, and snake-like, it looks like they are made out of taffy. Even if their teeth are made out of the same gooey substance as their body, the knight doesn't want to take any chances with them. Adora readies their sword, wondering what this battle will bring. Unsure yet what to do, the SOUL makes everyone defend.

It's a smart move. The taffy snakes launch an assault, spitting out balls of the sticky substance. Upon getting close, they explode into tiny pellets, striking the unsuspecting SOUL. Everyone winces at pain shoots through them.

Shake it off, Adora thinks.

It's time to ACT. Adora tries distracting the duo while Glimmer attempts a light spell to stun the snakes. Bow, meanwhile, shoots an arrow into the air, a net springing forth. The monsters quickly brush it all off. But this isn't the biggest shock to the trio. Sure, it's annoying for their ACTs to do little but they are used to it. What they are not used to is the SOUL suddenly slowing down.

Taffy sticks to it, weighing it down. The taffy snakes spit out their explosive bullets once more. Stunned and unable to properly

dodge, the SOUL is bombarded. The onslaught is so overwhelming, and the attack has caught everyone off guard, it swiftly downs *everyone.*

Adora watches in horror as the SOUL splits in two before shattering into tiny pieces. Pain explodes out of their chest, fire shooting throughout their body, leaving nothing untouched. They have no idea if they are screaming or if anyone can hear them. All they can see is darkness. All they can hear is nothingness. Even if the pain no longer feels like they have been thrown into a vant of *magma,* it continues to burn.

Fuck, fuck, fuck! Is all Adora can think of.

Don't give in, Adora! We need you here, please stay!

The SOUL appears between two bold, white words. *Continue* and *Give Up.* The SOUL shifts to the left, wanting to push forward.

In the blink of an eye, Adora returns to the shimmering save spot. The knight gasps as they come back to life. Their sight is assaulted by the bright neon lights and their ears ache from the loud, booming noises. Adora's body trembles, that fire lingering in their veins. They have to shake it off quickly. They cannot let anyone know about this fact. Adora takes a deep inhale, pushing everything deep down inside of them, before spinning on their heels.

Their friends chat about the same exact thing as before, the same exact words and mannerisms. They are none the wiser to Adora's blight.

You better not get me killed this time, they think, a growl within their mind.

Like before, Adora leads the way down the boardwalk. This time, however, when they near the same spot from before, they snap their head up.

“Whatcha looking at?” Glimmer asks. She turns her sights up as well. “If only we could figure out how to get on that thing. Then we can easily get to the fountain.”

“Yeah…” Adora squints their eyes, searching for the enemies.

**Glimmer, switch with Scorpia.*

“Are you sure about that?” Scorpia asks. She clicks the tips of her claws together. “I thought we were doing you, Bow, and Glimmer first.”

“I-I know. I just...I just have a feeling about something, ya know?” Adora replies, trying to hide the frustration in their voice. “I’m sorry.”

Glimmer gives her a nudge of the shoulders. “Hey, your gut has never led us astray. If you think something bad is gonna happen and this is the best course of action, then we’ll do it! Give me more time to think of ways to help out when I am in battle next!”

“Yeah! And I don’t get to fight with Scorpia a lot so this should be fun!” Bow exclaims. He gives a high-five with the scorpion monster.

Adora takes Glimmer’s hand in their own, placing a kiss on the back. “Thank you. I promise you’ll get to fight.”

The angel grins from ear to ear. “Just kick some extra ass for me, love.”

“I will, hon.”

After everything is set up, Adora takes several more steps, eyes carefully scanning the sky. With the awareness of the threat above, it doesn't take long for them to see a chair lift swinging. They pull out their sword just as the taffy monsters begin their descent. The battle starts, Scorpia and Bow right by Adora's side.

What to do, what to do...Why did the SOUL want Scorpia around and not Glimmer? Almost the same thing as before is repeated. Distraction, throwing a net, and magic. Though this time, it's electrical in nature. This stuns the taffy creatures, slowly their movements down. A plus for the group. Even if the attacks are not as fast, the SOUL is more than prepared for the bullets, swiftly dodging them all. Now knowing what is going on, the SOUL is ready to ACT.

Like yesterday with the puppet monster, it is a dual combo that finishes the battle. When Bow fires off his net arrow, Scorpia combines her magic. Adora watches as the net falls on both the taffy snakes and gives them a good shock, stunning them fully. Spent, they slither off.

"Huh, that wasn't too bad," Bow says.

You're lucky you don't remember before, Adora thinks to themself. They can't fully shake the lingering feelings of pain from their body. Maybe some of the dark funnel cake will do them some good. The powdery, fried dough does taste amazing against their lips. They really should get some back in their world.

"You guys good to keep moving?" Adora asks after swallowing their food. When the others give a nod, showing no signs of weariness, they push on. This area of the world has a number of puzzles, more so than monsters. Though, they are less like puzzles and more like *games* . Trying to get rings on necks of bottles, shooting hoops, trying to knock cans over, and more carnival games. And just like the ones in their own world, Adora is pretty sure they are rigid. It takes many times to get past each one.

At one of those games where you have to knock down stuffed dummies, Adora and Catra step up to the plate. Besides trying to keep moving forward and reach their destination, the two want to one up each other. For a moment, their eyes lock, each *daring* the other to a challenge. Despite their new found friendship, a rivalry still burns deep inside. Neither wants to lose to the other.

Adora knows how to throw a ball. After all, they were a pitcher on their softball team for a while. Yet, as per usual now, the SOUL is the one who decides where the bag in their hand sails. Whatever is in control of their body either wants to purposely fuck with them or they never have thrown a ball before. Adora cannot strike anything. If they do, it is only a nip. A small gust of wind that makes the stuffed dummy mock them for their poor aim.

"Rusty, Adora?" Catra teases, already knocking everything over on her end. There is a shit-eating grin on her face. The monster behind the counter gives the magicat a small, stuffed parrot-chicken. She thinks for a moment before spinning on her heels, shoving the thing in front of Scorpia. "Here!"

The scorpion monster doesn't know how to act right away, caught off guard. But a small smile appears on her face as she takes it. "Thank you."

Adora curses under their breath. They really wish they could throw the ball themself and finally win. It's the only way to keep moving forward. Another look at their watch. There still is time but not enough to waste. A growl escapes them.

Soft hands wrap around their wrist. Glimmer steps closer, pushing herself up enough to whisper into her partner's ear. "Let me help you, love."

"Thank you."

"Don't you dare use any magic," the shark monster with water filters on their gills states.

As if you guys don't make this almost impossible on purpose. Adora.

"Don't worry your sandpaper scales off." Glimmer huffs. "Okay, ready, 'Dora?"

There is nothing the SOUL can do but sit back and watch Glimmer help Adora throw. Which, the knight is not complaining in the

slightest. Glimmer pulls her partner's hand back. Together, they throw the sack. Finally, one of the stuffed dummies is knocked over. With a boost of confidence and the help from their girlfriend, they finally manage to knock everything they need. The monster gives a shrug before handing the pair a stuffed four winged bird.

"Yo, Bow, you want this? Something to make up for being the fifth wheel?" Adora asks.

Bow shakes his head. "You guys keep it, don't worry."

Everything is packed away. There are several other puzzles and games everyone must do before any headway can be made towards the fountain. The shops and rides and even monsters begin to spread thin. Even their battles have become less frequent. Adora gets a sinking feeling in their chest that something is going to happen. They gulp, feeling beads of sweat forming on their brow. Silence is never good. As much as they are eager to see the gushing water, it is not the best sign either. The hair on the back of their neck stands at full attention. Doesn't help that only a few feet back they used a save point.

The boardwalk comes to a broken, shattered end. Jagged ends stick out of the now murky water, along with abandoned carnival booths and rides. Dark clouds with the threat of thunder hang above and there no longer is a warm breeze. It's bone chilling. Adora takes a step back, their foot nearly going through a hole in the wood. What in both worlds will this monster be?

The water around them begins to swirl, becoming a whirlpool of the broken wood and metal. It begins to twist towards the sky, turning to a fast moving tornado. Wind picks up, nearby sand particles slice up skin. Even the SOUL does not get away unscathed, taking several sharp hits. Adora groans as they feel their body takes double damage. Through squinted eyes, the knight watches the monster take its final form.

A large, intimidating stallion. The broken pieces of wood and metal make up its skeleton. All of its vertebrae, rib cage, skull—

everything. Other pieces float around in its water body and tail. Neon lights form their eyes and every snort it takes, steam pours out its nostrils. The thing must be two or three stories tall.

"Holy fuckin' shit!" Catra shouts.

That is all anyone can get out before the large monster rears back onto it's back legs. There is barely enough time to jump out of the way before its front hooves come crashing down, breaking a large part of the boardwalk. The battle has begun with Catra and Bow at Adora's side.

"Damn, guess this is going to be hard without Scorpia's magic," Catra mumbles. "Arrow Head! You got any electric arrows?"

"Some but they aren't as powerful," Bow replies.

Well, if we die then I know we need to keep Scorpia on, Adora thinks. *Hopefully that won't happen.*

"Let's kick this horse's ass." Adora says themself.

ACTing time. The SOUL takes time to think, not sure what to do with a foe such as this. It's a mix of defend by Adora, an attack by Catra, and an ACT by Bow with his electrified arrows. The water horse grunts, clearly taking some damage. Whatever it took, the monster quickly shakes it off as if they are annoying flies. Now it is its turn to attack.

The SOUL struggles to dodge blasts of steam from its nose. Hot air strikes the heart. Repeat. Try to chip away at the water horse or try to knock it out. For every hit the trio gets in, the monster gets twice that. Adora is the first to go down, forced to watch their friends struggle to fight on without them. The water horse proves to be too much. Adora braces themself as they watch the SOUL shattered.

Pain.

Voices.

Continue.

Adora gasps as they return to the last place they saved. For a second time, they have ‘died’. For a second time, they have felt the burning pain be injected into their bones. For the second time, they have failed to protect others. They don’t want to feel that for a third time.

A hand slaps on their shoulder. Bow. “Let’s keep moving. We are getting close to the fountain.”

“R-Right,” Adora says. They shake off the stinging sensation swimming about their body as best they can. With the previous still lingering,it only does so much. “Let’s go.”

Before moving too close to the end of the boardwalk, Scorpia takes Bow’s place. Maybe with her might, this can work. Everyone can get home before it is pitch black out. Adora leads the way back to the end of the world. With their previous attempt here, they are able to jump over most of the holes or loose boards. Everyone follows their lead, not questioning where they are stepping. As the water monster begins to form, Adora has more time to throw up their arms and shield themself from the storm. Even the SOUL is ready for the hail of rubble being thrown around.

When the battle starts up, the SOUL is quick to ACT and fight. Seems like they do not want to be stuck here forever either. Focus is on Scorpia’s own magic. The blast of red electricity cuts through the air and connects with one of the metal slabs. This time, the damage is strong. The water horse whines, throwing its head back. Though, this only seems to *piss* it off. Hooves slam hard against the water and the rest of the boardwalk. The SOUL does its best to weave in and out of the barrage but one good stomp shatters it.

Fuck!

This is far from the last time this occurs. No matter how many times everyone faces off against the water creature, it pummels the living shit out of everyone. Each time, the pain in Adora's body grows, unable to keep up with the onslaught. The voices they hear in that darkness becomes static, going in one ear and out the other, as they become desensitized to the words. How on earth can they keep going when a stupid horse is kicking their ass? Even the SOUL is sharing their frustration.

ACTs are less often unless they can do substantial damage. Fighting is where it is at, everyone giving it their all. After each death, after each time Adora is thrown back to minutes before, there is a switch up. Maybe, just maybe, one dynamic is better than the other. *Still,* nothing is working. By the...Adora has lost track honestly. They know it's more than the fingers on their hand. By this time, they are about to *scream.*

As they return again to their save point, they can no longer stand. Adora winces in pain as their legs collapse from under them. Knees smack against the board, the armor on them preventing splinters. One arm shoots out to break their fall while the other grasps their body. They gasp for air, barely able to expel or inhale anything. Their whole body trembles as the fiery pain refuses to leave them. Anything inside their stomach feels like it is about to be thrown up.

Damn it! Damn it! Why can't we win! Adora hisses to themself. *Why can't we win! Why can't **YOU** win!*

There is a ring in their ears. The world spins around as if they are on a spinning ride that plasters you to the wall from sheer force of pressure. This is one, if not *the,* worst experience they have ever felt. Maybe next time they'll find a way to *force* the SOUL to 'give up' just so they no longer have to deal with this anymore.

"ADORA!" Glimmer's voice breaks through the ring. In the swirl of colors around them, they manage to pull their girlfriend into focus. Worry is etched into every inch of her face. They can feel

her rubbing her hand on their back. Maybe even some soothing magic. “Are you okay?!? What happened?!?”

“I’m fine! I’m fine!” Adora gasps. They hope she can't see through their lie. “I-I-I-” they cannot think of anything else to say.

“You look like a ghost.” Bow adds on, kneeling at Adora’s other side. “Why did you collapse like that?”

**It’s nothing! I’m fine!*

Both Glimmer and Bow look at them in shock, unable to believe their ears. They exchange worried looks with one another. Adora bites down hard on their lower lip, wishing those words never fell out of their mouth. They look over their shoulder. Catra and Scorpia share the same sentiment. Neither seem to know what to do, taken back by the rise in their friend’s voice.

“Adora?” Glimmer softly says.

“I didn’t mean to yell, I’m sorry.” Adora slowly pushes themself up to their feet, not caring what their body is saying. If they don’t do it now, the SOUL surely will force them up. They wobble for a moment, legs wanting to give up and not do any work. Glimmer and Bow each take an arm and help them up, refusing to let go right away.

“I can stand by myself,” Adora tells them. They don’t know if this is a lie or not. Every time they try to think of something other than the hot pain coursing through their body, it quickly boots the other thought to the curve. *Okay, maybe I can’t…*

“No offense, Adora, you look like shit. No, strike that, shit looks better than you,” Catra bluntly states.

“ *Thanks* , Catra…”

“She has a point. You don’t look like you should be standing or doing anything,” Bow says.

* *I can walk. We have to proceed.*

Adora feels themself pulling away from their girlfriend and best friend. The SOUL refuses to give them a moment to recover, to try thinking of ways to ease their friends' worries. All they can do, with the lack of energy, is let the thing inside of them do what it wants. Adora cannot even turn their head around to see everyone's reaction to them staggering off. They hold back the tears forming in their eyes.

The others begin to follow, boards squeaking and groaning from their weights. When the water horse begins to form, Adora barely twitches as everything spins around them, threatening to slice up their cheeks. For this battle, Glimmer and Scorpia fight by Adora's side. Out of the corner of their sights, they see their girlfriend watching them closely. Adora turns their head away, unable to bear the gaze.

If there is one good thing about dying a bunch of times, it's that the SOUL knows all the attacks the water horse has to offer. It easily dodges everything being thrown at it. The monster before them can barely lay a hit before a flurry of attacks come from the trio. Adora with their sword, Glimmer with her various spells and light powers, and Scorpia with her advantageous electricity. The horse tries over and over again to bring someone to their knees, sending steam or broken up carnival rides at them. But with the SOUL's knowledge of each and every attack, and all the funnel cake in everyone's pocket, there is nothing it can do. Even the dash of good luck is around and finally, *finally,* it falls.

Adora, Glimmer, and Scorpia combined their attacks. The angel starts off with a large, bright ball of light, blinding anyone dumb enough to look right at it. As the water horse shakes the light from its eyes, Adora and Scorpia work together. Taking cues from the last boss battle, the knight throws their metal sword towards the living water. The scorpion monster uses her lightning to create a missile of static right into its heart. With no strength left, the monster before everyone explodes.

“Get down!” Adora shouts as wood and metal is pulled down by the invisible force of gravity. Everyone finds cover, Adora, Glimmer, and Bow shielding each other and Scorpia shielding Catra. Thankfully, the only thing that hits anyone are large blobs of water. Once everything has settled and there no longer is a threat of being impaled, everyone slowly looks towards the sky. The clouds have begun to fade, showing off the sky. Water calms down and there is nothing sticking out of it. The only oddity is the dark fountain that continues to shoot gallons upon gallons into the far reaches of the world.

“God, I hate being wet,” Catra grumbles. She turns to look at Scorpia. “Are you okay? Uh, ...T-Thank you for shielding me.”

“N-No problem! Here, let me help you up!” Scorpia shifts and gets Catra to her feet.

“You guys alright?” Adora asks Glimmer and Bow. All three get to their feet, wet to the bone.

“Fine.” Bow says. He wrings his cape the best he can.

“What about you? How are you holding up?” Glimmer asks. “You are looking better but…”

Adora gulps, just waiting for the SOUL to say something. There isn’t much time to explain everything. Even if they had it, where would they even begin? “I...I’ll be fine, Glim. I’ll explain everything eventually but...I am fine right now.”

“Do you promise?”

“I promise.”

“Okay.” Glimmer says this with some hesitancy in her voice.

“Hey, has anyone seen that princess?” Catra cuts in. She looks around the area, feet at the edge of the boardwalk.

Adora takes their own look around. Where *is* the princess? Is there even one in this world? They carefully step to the broken end of the boardwalk. Calm water stares back at them. Adora leans closer, seeing their tired and beaten reflection. They are just about to pull away when ripples begin. For a moment, the knight thinks that this is a trick or the water horse is coming back for seconds. They place their hand on the hilt of their sword but there is no need. A head pops out of the water.

She has dark blue hair tied in a braid. Seafoam blue scales are on her dark face and shoulders. Sticking out an arm, Adora sees more scales and even fins attached to their elbow. A similar colored tail sticks out from behind her. "So, like, you guys saved me."

"Yes." Adora replies, blinking. "Uh, are you the princess?"

She nods. "I am Mermista."

"Where they hell were you?" Catra asks.

"That water horse trapped me under water. Thankfully, I can breathe just fine." Mermista points to the gills on her neck. "Thank you for your help back there. You really saved my ass."

"Not a problem." Adora says. "Now if you excuse me, I have to go close this stupid thing."

Adora walks over to the flowing fountain. They really have had enough water for the day, maybe a whole *week.* The SOUL pops out of their body and does it's work. Adora barely reacts to the light, too tired from everything. Once the fountain is shut, it shoots back into their body. Time to skedaddle back to Brightmoon.

Adora watches Frosta and Catra hide in the bushes, waiting for some pour sap to pass them by. That unlucky person is Perfuma. After getting to know Mermista, the plant elf takes a stroll right into their path. Despite still being soaked, Catra happily uses a

water gun alongside the younger Darkner and douses Perfuma. Though, escape is impossible. The elf captures them in her vines in a matter of moments.

“Yo, Adora.”

Arms wrap around their waist and large wings almost totally encase them. “What’s up, hon?”

Glimmer places her chin on Adora’s shoulder. “Are you feeling any better?”

Adora leans back against their girlfriend. “Yeah. How are you doing?”

“I’m fine. You know I am worried about you. You’ve been acting odd. That outburst wasn’t like you. Do you want to talk about it?”

“Not right now. Sorry...I’m just really beat.”

They feel Glimmer’s warm lips press against the crook of their neck. “Okay. I’ll see you tomorrow then?”

Adora spins in her arms, becoming face to face with their girlfriend. They place their own kiss on her forehead. “Tomorrow. Love you, Glim.”

“Love you too, ‘Dora.”

Returning to their own world goes much smoother. No one falls on top of the other. No one even trips. By the looks of it, no one has made their way in here either. Adora is about to sigh a breath of relief, happy not to be crushed or caught, when their eyes land on the windows. There are hints of the sun. Only the lights from the stars and moon give anyone sight. Adora looks at their watch, confused as they thought there still was time. However, it hits them like a truck.

“Fuckin’ turning the clocks back!” Adora shouts, kicking at nothing.

“What?” Catra asks. “Why are you flipping out again?”

“I forgot it gets darker earlier! I promised my mom I wouldn’t be out late. Look how dark it is outside!” They run their fingers down their face. “What the hell am I going to do?”

Catra and Scorpa whisper to each other before nodding. The magicat steps up to her friend. “Can I see your watch for a second?”

“What? Why?”

“Just trust me, alright?”

Adora grumbles as they remove their watch. The moment it is in Catra’s hand, the magicat slams it down on the ground. Before Adora can protest, both monsters have slammed their heels down on the watch.

“What the hell was that for!” Adora seethes.

Catra places a finger on their forehead. “Think for a second. You said your mom is gonna kill you right? Well, how can she if you tell her you didn’t know what time it was?”

Adora blinks. “What?”

Scorpia bends out and picks up the broken piece of metal and gears. “Sorry for breaking it. But Catra is right. How can she be mad if you say that?”

“Well, we still need to explain why we are all wet. She’ll be mad about that.”

Catra shrugs. “We will come with you to lessen the blow. And we can tell her we were goofing off at the lake and that’s why we are wet and why your watch is broken.”

“Thanks guys…”

Catra grins a sharp tooth grin. It goes from ear to ear. She wraps an arm around Adora’s neck. “Of course! Someone’s gotta keep you out of trouble for all you do for us. Let’s go.”

Adora, Catra, and Scorpia make their way to the blonde’s house. Each step they take sends their heart beating harder in their chest. It feels like it's about to explode out of their chest. Having the magicat and the scorpion around definitely helps ease their anxiety. They joke around with them, trying to lighten their mood.

Their home comes into focus. All the lights in the first floor are on. Adora can see two dark silhouettes pacing around in the kitchen. They gulp a dry lump that has formed in their throat. If they had a tail like Catra or Scorpia, it would be tucked between their legs.

“Are you ready, Hotshot?” Scorpia asks.

“N-No,” Adora stutters. “But do I have a choice?”

“We got your back. Don’t worry!” Catra adds.

The three walk forward, stopping on the mat on the front porch. Adora takes a deep breath and raises a first to the wooden door. They don’t get the chance to knock. The door suddenly flies open. Their mother’s arms wrap around them, squeezing them tight.

“Oh, thank god you are okay!” Marlena sniffs. Though this quickly changes to anger. She pulls away and there is a fire in her dark blue eyes. “Where the hell were you! Why are you three wet?!?”

“I-” Adora starts.

“Sorry, Mrs. Marlena,” Scorpia cuts her off. “We all were having so much fun together we lost track of time.”

“Yeah ma’am. And we lost track of time quite literally.” Catra digs into her pocket and pulls out the shattered watch. “I can buy them a new one.”

“Don’t be mad at them. We were trying to be good. If anything, we kept them too long.”

Marlena stares down all three, eyes narrow. Adora knows that face. Their mother is searching for any hints of a lie. Catra is the best bullshitter around, she’ll be hard to call out. Scorpia on the other hand, Adora doesn’t know if they ever heard her lie. Just over Marlena’s shoulder, Adora spots their father watching intently over his glasses.

They feel their heart beating even harder in their chest. How hasn’t it exploded and broke into a million pieces like when the SOUL breaks. Finally, their mother backs down. She sighs before hugging their child once more. “Okay. I’m just happy you’re okay. You had us so worried.”

Adora returns the gesture. “I’m sorry, Mom. Dad. I didn’t mean to.”

“Thank you girls for bringing them home.” Randor says. “Would you two like to stay for dinner? It would be nice to have more than three people around the table again.”

“You know what! I will take you up on that offer, Old Man! I’m starving!” Catra states before waltzing into the house.

“What did she call me?” Randor says under his breath.

“I would love that, Mr. Randor.” Scorpia answers. “Do you mind if I phone my moms to let them know I’ll be eating here tonight?”

“Not at all!”

Adora follows Scorpia into the living room. The moment the door clicks behind them, the moment they are temporarily separated from their friends, they are stopped. Two hands, one on each shoulder, keeps them in place. *Shit!*

“Adora.” Randor starts. “We are happy you are having fun with your friends. Though not as happy over the fact you broke your

promise today."

"We aren't going to punish you or anything, as long as you don't keep this up but," Marlena takes a moment to think. "Your behaviour is worrying us. Is there something else going on? We know school is rough and you miss your brother but…Honey. You can talk to us."

Adora grips their sweater, dead center in their chest. It takes everything in them not to hyperventilate at this point. Their mouth goes dry as they struggle to say *anything.* Be it a lie or the truth or a combination of the two. They take too long.

* *It's nothing. I swear.*

"Are you sure?" Randor presses.

* *Yes. Can I go be with my friends now?*

Randor and Marlena whisper to each other before agreeing to let their child go. Adora hesitates for a moment, wishing they got the chance to say their own words to their parents. There is nothing to do now other than join the laughing monsters at the table.

Adora stares up at the glow in the dark stars and moon on their ceiling. Their body is tired, feeling like it has been run over by every car in Etheria. Even their mind is a tangled, jumbled up mess where one thought can barely finish a sentence. Yet, they remain awake. Sleep nothing more than an illusion. So tired they are, they cannot pull the SOUL out of their body. Alone, Adora allows it to float above their chest, lighting their body up in a soft glow.

They still wonder what this thing is. Why did it choose them as its host? Why does it make them do and say things they normally wouldn't? Why does it have to control them like a puppet and make them suffer death after death after death. Why can't it leave them alone?

Adora looks over at their clock. ***2am.*** They sigh, wondering if sleep will ever find them. At least then, they can have some peace and not worry about everything going on.

Maybe the SOUL can hear their thoughts as well. If it does, even with all the hate they have thrown at it, it gives them mercy. Adora sees two words side by side. *Sleep* or *Stay awake.* The SOUL moves towards the first one. Suddenly, darkness creeps along Adora's sights. Their whole body becomes like lead and shapes lose their lines. For once, they find themself muttering a thank you to the SOUL before sleep overwhelms them.

Chapter End Notes

kudos/comments appreciated

Mr. Roboto

Chapter Notes

Eh posted early for reasons fuck it. Hoped yall enjoyed this little fic it was fun to do!!!

Also so yall know werewolf au won't come back next Sunday. I need one more week to queue but also I MYSELF need a week to not worry about posting so yeah.

Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora groans as they awaken. Their body warmth has been sealed shut by the blankets around them. The world outside of their cocoon is chilly. They bury themself deeper, making a mental note to start wearing a shirt instead of their tank top with how the weather is now. In their half awake world, Adora slowly flutters open their eyes. Bird songs fill their ears and light seeps in through the curtains. Their mother's cooking fills the room in a savoury, mouth watering smell. The light from the sun is bright and welcoming. Honestly, Adora could slip right back into their dreams. What's the harm in shutting their eyes for five more minutes? They let their eyelids close.

…

Wait, why is the light so bright?

Adora's eyes fly open. In their sudden realization, they begin to twist onto their stomach but blankets entangle them. They slip out of their bed, gravity taking a hold. Their left shoulder takes the brunt of the fall, pain radiating to their upper rib cage. Adora scrambles to free themself out of their entanglement. When they manage to twist their head up, eyes quickly land on the glass window. The sky is a brilliant bright blue, the same as their eyes. Quickly, they turn to their digital clock on their nightstand. The

last time they checked, it was the middle of the night. Now, the red numbers read ***9:13.***

How the hell did I sleep through my alarm?!? Shit. I am so fuckin' late!

Adora pulls themself free of their covers, scrambling to get ready for the day. Even the SOUL seems caught off guard by this. They blindly stumble down the stairs, their sweater blocking their sights. There is no time to brush their hair or teeth or even eat for that matter. They gotta get to school, and fast.

They bump into something, nearly toppling over from the sudden hit.

"Adora!" they hear their mother say. "Come here."

Another set of hands grip the sweater, tugging it downward. Adora's head pops free. Out of the red and gold wool, the first thing they see is their mother. "Ma?!? What are you doing here! Why didn't you wake me! I'm late!"

"Slow your roll, 'Dora! You aren't going to school today."

"What?!? *Why?!?"*

"You are staying home for the day. We already called Huntara." Adora hears their father's voice step out of the bathroom. They spin around to face the older man. "Your mother took off also and I closed the shop for the day."

"Okay but that still doesn't answer 'why'!"

"We talked last night and decided to keep you home for your own sake." Marlena steps closer to her child. "You're still not in trouble but we don't want you going out today."

"How is that ' *not in trouble'* ?"

"Let me finish. If you are stressing out, if it is what is causing your odd behaviour, maybe you should relax at home. You can do whatever you want. Watch TV, play video games all day, whatever! Just, stay home and relax."

I can't really do that when I have the Dark World to worry about.
"Can I at least go out with Catra and Scorpia?"

Marlena crosses her arms against her chest. "Okay maybe we did make this a bit of a punishment. No."

"You guys keep getting into trouble. One day away from them won't do you any harm," Randor states.

"But-!"

"No 'buts', Adora!" Marlena firmly tells her child. Her dark eyes are serious. The face of an immovable being stares straight back at Adora. For all their battles, all their deaths in the Dark World, the look of their mother is the most frightening thing they have ever seen. Fighting Marlena will only result in an actual grounding.

The SOUL doesn't seem to have gotten this memo.

Adora sees the invisible words out in front of them, the SOUL dead set in the middle. One side is a simple *Okay.* Meanwhile, the other side is a defiant ' *You can't do that!'* The red heart only they can see begins moving towards the latter.

*Don't you **dare!***

They grit their teeth together, fists shaking as they fight against what is inside them. The SOUL stops before reaching their destination. Any looks their parents might be making at the sight Adora ignores. With all their might, they fight back against the SOUL, somehow pulling it towards the other end. It's a fight, a tug-of-war for what path will be taken. Glimmer must have rubbed off of them as Adora gets the SOUL towards where they want.

* *Okay.*

Their parents sigh in relief. Randor speaks first. “Thank you for understanding, honey. Tomorrow you can go to school and see your friends. It’s just for today.”

“I can make you something special for breakfast. Go sit and relax,” Marlena adds on.

She walks over to the stove top, returning to her cooking. Randor settles down on the couch, turning on the TV. Adora lets go of the breath stuck in their throat. Fighting for control has sapped them of a good amount of energy. They really would love to go back to bed right about now. Hands continue to shake, something they try to hide. With nothing else to do, and now under the watchful eyes of their parents, Adora trudges over to the couch.

They flop down on the couch, their upper body rests on the cushions, lower on the arm rest, while legs hang freely. Eyes stare at the flashing images on the TV screen. Their father stops on some day time talk show no one really listens to. He sets the remote off to the side and places a hand on his child hand, rubbing their dark blonde locks.

“You know we love you, right?” he says.

“I know,” Adora mumbles, enjoying the fatherly touch.

“It’s just for a day. And what’s more fun than hanging out with your old man? We can watch a horrible movie and rip on it. Just like old times. What do you say?”

Adora chuckles. An old family past time that has become few and far between since life started to become more hectic. College, high school, work, and other things in general. Maybe staying home today isn’t such a bad idea. The younger blonde rolls onto their back, keeping their legs hanging off the couch.

“Sure, Dad. I would love that. Though, is it going to be one of those campy movies from the 80s?”

Randor has already pulled out a VHS tape, practically out of thin air. His eyes are wide with a sparkle growing inside. “What if it is?”

“I get to pick the next one then.”

Randor fiddles around with the VCR and TV before putting in the tape. He sits down just in time for Marlena to bring food. She takes her own seat with her husband and child. Adora sometimes finds themself taking a glance out the window, staring at the orange world outside of theirs. They wonder what their friends are doing. If they are wondering why they are missing. Guess there will be no going into the Dark World at all today.

Their parents keep bringing them back into the movie with their witty comments about what is going on. Adora really doesn't want to miss out on getting a good jab in. For some brief periods, they are so lost in what is playing out in front of them, they lose track of time. They forget why they are still home on a weekday. Relaxation is something they did not realize how much they needed.

It is not until the third movie does something break their train of thought. A hard, rapid knock on the front door. Randor pauses the movie that plays, jumps to his feet, and heads to see who is creating the noise. Standing on the front porch are Catra and Scorpia. The magicat has her fist in the air. The scorpion monster stands off to the side, shifting on her feet.

“There you are!” Catra shouts. She attempts to step closer but is blocked by Randor’s arm. “Hey!”

“Dad!” Adora gets off the couch and joins their father at the door. They look at their two friends. “Hey guys.”

“So you *aren’t* sick. I fuckin’ knew it.”

“Catra, you can be a little bit nicer,” Scorpia interjects. She turns her attention to Adora. “How are you?”

“Fine. I kind of was forced to stay home.”

“What?” Catra and Scorpia say together.

“Yes, about that.” Randor looks at Adora before turning his sights to their friends. “Marlena and I decided to keep Adora home today for their own sake. And before either of you asks, no, they cannot come out. You three can do whatever tomorrow, just not today.”

“Are you serious?!?” Catra spats. She puffs herself out, a feeble attempt to look intimidating against the towering man. Randor doesn’t bat an eye.

“Yes I am.”

“Adora needs a day off from excitement and trouble making.” Marlena says from behind. Judging by the faces on their two friends, Adora knows their mother is giving them quite the glare. “You can see them tomorrow.”

“I can’t even have them over?” Adora says, slightly surprised.

“No. Lord knows the chaos you three could cause just being in the house. Don’t try to fight and make it worse.”

Adora sees the SOUL popping out, hovering between two sentences. One that would cause an argument with their mother and another to ease any tension hanging in the air. Before it can make a decision or even think, Adora uses the pause to move the SOUL themself. Another hit to their energy bar but they don’t care. Speaking for themself, even if it is not quite the words they would choose.

**Yeah, guys. I'll see you tomorrow!*

Adora forces a smile. Truthfully, Adora wishes their friends could come in at the very least. What’s the harm in that? Not like a Dark World would appear out of thin air in their home. But with the energy spent on trying to have some semblance of control, they don’t need to spend more on fighting.

“Don’t get into too much trouble without me, ‘kay?” they add.

A disappointed look grows on both monsters' faces. Scorpia removes the backpack on her before digging around in it. She pulls out a stack of papers. "Well, here then. Homework from Ms. Huntara. Said not to slack at all on it."

Adora grabs the homework. "Thank you." They wave their friends good-bye, watching them slowly step away. Once the door closes, Adora sets the stack of papers on an end table.

"Tomorrow you can spend time with them, alright?" Randor says. "Let's finish up our movie watch and then do your homework. Your mother and I can help if needed."

"Sure. Thanks, Dad."

"You okay, honey? I know you are upset but you also look...a little worn out." Marlena states.

You'd be too if you had to fight something controlling you. "It's nothing. Let's get back to that movie."

Everyone settles down on the couch to return to their fun. Though, Adora starts to nod off at points, struggling to stay awake.

Man this SOUL is a pain in the ass…

Adora never thought they'd be so happy to be in school. It's not like they *hate* it, they actually love to learn and challenge their mind. Huntara's loud and expressive greeting in the morning definitely helped make their morning as well as being back with their friends. Now that is all over for the day, the weekend is at hand. Something else to lift up their spirits. However, they need to stay out of trouble. Anything more will cause more, serious punishment

But the Dark World beckons for them to enter. They cannot refuse it for a second day.

“Hurry up, slow poke!” Catra shouts, jogging down the sidewalk. “We gotta check if it’s still open!”

“I’m coming, I’m coming!” Adora snaps back. “I’m sure it’ll still be there!”

“It better be!”

Adora and Scorpia follow close behind, trying to keep up with the magicat’s speed and agility. The cold air sucked in by Adora nips at their lungs. They really wish Catra would slow down a little. Despite Adora being active and on their feet a lot, if this keeps up by the time they reach the auto shop, they might as well collapse. They never fully recovered from their fight with the SOUL yesterday.

Catra skids to a halt, the small auto shop appearing. Catra’s father, Caracal, owns the place. He shares his daughter’s scrappy build and height, though has quite the hidden strength. His own cat ears are cut up from here and there accidents at his work, even scars riddle his dark furred tail and body. Honestly, the pair look almost the same except Caracal’s slightly taller height, black short hair, and both his eyes being cyan.

The magicat peers through a window. Her tail begins to flick with excitement. "Okay good news. I see the Dark World opening. And my Pops isn't in the back room. We are good to go in."

"Are you sure your dad isn't going to randomly appear?" Adora questions.

Catra digs into her pocket and pulls out a key. She unlocks the door, pushing it open. “I’m sure. Even if he appears I told him we would stop by at one point. Didn’t say when so he won’t be surprised if he catches us just after we exit. C’mon.”

Adora sighs as they follow Catra into the back room. Caracal uses the room for keeping track of bills and what not and to take his breaks. There is a desk littered with pens, papers, and some scrap metal. There is a mini fridge under the desk and a two seat couch

off to the side. The air is filled with the strong scent of oil and gasoline. There are black fingerprints all over the place, so dried up they permanently stain the surfaces they rest on. Muffed chatter and metallic noises seep through the closed door to the main building. Adora wonders if Caracal has any idea his daughter and her friends are here.

Catra shows her two friends the portal to the Dark World. The closet.

"I don't know if only we can see it or my Pops just hasn't noticed," Catra starts, "but I saw it yesterday. My dad likes to drag me here in the morning sometimes and I noticed it. Hung around here yesterday making sure it didn't go away so you could get us in it."

"Well, I'm here now, aren't I?" Adora grabs the center of their sweater, knowing the SOUL is crawling around inside, waiting to make a move. The key to allowing anyone inside the Dark World. Catra and Scorpia have tried before, only to be thrown backwards by the darkness, rejecting their presence until Adora arrived.

Adora steps forward, ready to enter the Dark World. They wonder where it will take them and their friends. Darkness envelops them, changing their clothing. The first thing that their senses pick up on are hammers smacking against metal. Within the blackness, bright orange sparks fly about. This time the temperature is like that of the inside of an oven. Adora really does not like that idea of wearing heat absorbing armor. They brace themself at a hard, metal ground comes up.

There is a reverberation as feet touch down. Adora takes a quick look around, gathering their surroundings. The past two worlds were full of organic life. Lush trees, rolling waves, a place any number of creatures could be hiding while they live their life. Here everything is manufactured, the only 'living' things are them, Catra, and Scorpia. Metal is all around them. Steel is lifted upward, slowly joining its siblings in the creation of buildings. Robots with tools for hands meld everything together. On the ground below, more robots zip and zoom by, carrying items and

what have you. They are connected to slits on the ground, creating two lanes like a street.

And the trio is on one side of the traffic.

They scramble out of the way of oncoming robots, who either don't notice them or don't care if they hit others. Adora gasps after a narrow miss, feeling the gust of wind nip at their ankles. They are still on the road, stunned. Scorpia thankfully grabs them by the collar of their undershirt, picks them up, and sets them down on the metal sidewalk.

"Thanks," Adora says.

"This place sure is bustling," Catra mumbles. She sticks her fingers in her ears. "And fuckin' loud."

"Guess we should be extra careful. I don't like the idea of being run over."

"We should find Glimmer and Bow. They could get lost in a place like this," Scorpia points out.

Right. Crap, I forgot about my promise!

Adora wastes no time in marching forward. Catra and Scorpia match their pace, all keeping an eye out for any monsters wanting to start up a fight. They turn corners, trying to avoid being run over by fast moving robots, crossing streets when they can, and attempting to avoid all random pockets of construction. Every time they pass someone creating sparks, working with heat, or blowing off steam, Adora feels sweat *dripping* down their face. They swear the SOUL is beginning to take damage. What they wouldn't do for some water right about now? Do knights *have* to wear armor?

Hairs on the back of Adora's neck stand at attention. The air around them suddenly feels off, as if the temperature has dropped. They manage to spin around in time to see a flurry of lilac feathers covering their vision. As a new weight pushes down

on them, Adora manages to brace themself for the impact to the cold, hard ground.

“There you are!!!” Glimmer cries, violet eyes full of tears. “I was so scared yesterday!”

“I’m okay, Glim. It just was a day!”

“Yeah but you said you’d come yesterday. I waited all day! And...And you had me so worried!”

Adora tilts their head. They push themself up onto their elbows. “What do you mean?”

“You’ve been acting odd these past few days! Don’t try to hide it!” Glimmer’s wings puff out with her growing emotions. “I didn’t know if something had happened! I don’t know what goes on in your world, you could’ve been hurt or worse! Don’t you scare me like that again!”

“Hey, hey. Shh,” Adora wraps their arms around their girlfriend, squeezing them tight, letting her know this is real. They bury their face into the crook of the angel’s neck, taking in her flowery scent. “I’m here now, aren’t I? I’m okay.”

“ *Are* you?” Glimmer asks, some sharpness to her voice.

I really don’t know… “Yes.”

“Don’t worry. They just got grounded for the day like a loser,” Catra snickers.

"Don’t make me push you into traffic!”

Catra bursts out laughing, no, *cackling* , as she walks away. Glimmer sits up, remaining on Adora’s lap. The knight sits up as well, though, wobbling slightly. Damn this heat is killer. “You don’t happen to have water on you, do you? My armor is killing me.”

"Yeah. And Frosta actually taught me something that might help. Hold on."

Glimmer digs out a water bottle, which Adora happily gulps down. While they do that, their girlfriend creates a spell. It is a *pale* blue, almost white in nature. The knight can feel an iciness to it as it forms into a small ball. Glimmer mumbles words they cannot understand before she pushes it forward. It enters their body, meeting no resistance. The moment it does, Adora's whole body chills. It feels like they are back in Frosta's ice and snow coated world.

"God that feels good, thank you," Adora sighs. Now they won't die of heat stroke.

Ready, Adora and Glimmer rise to their feet. Now that there is no need for panic, the knight can properly greet their other friend. They embrace, happy to see each other. With everyone gathered and ready for the adventure ahead, it is time to get moving. Before taking any further steps, Adora looks around for any signs of the sought out fountain. All the metal buildings reach high into the sky, blocking out much of the skyline. *Great.*

Part of Adora wants to locate the fountain themself but the SOUL fully wakes. It tugs at Adora and pulls them forward. Everyone else follows their lead. With all the foot traffic and actual traffic, walking is a challenge. Single file is a **must.** Even then, there is no escaping a bump to the shoulders. Thankfully, the SOUL does not take any damage. Don't need to start off a fight already weakened.

The knight takes another look around, getting an even better look at their surroundings. Everywhere they look, there is some sort of construction going on. Everyone is on the move, barely slowing down even at the crosswalks. It is a quick lesson learned about not keeping up with the pace. Being one step too slow and someone will say some rude remark. Catra always shoots back with her own–Scorpia keeping her calm enough not to start a fist fight.

“So,” Glimmer starts, talking loud enough for the knight to hear her from behind. “You got grounded?”

Adora scoffs. “All but in name. My parents said it wasn’t that but it was.”

“What the hell did you do?”

“Nothing, honest. My parents were...they didn’t like me coming home late and sneaking around.”

“So did we get you in trouble?” Bow asks. His voice is *just* audible.

“No! No, it’s none of your guys' fault. Trust me! You all did nothing!” Adora attempts to spin around, to look at their friends. They need to reassure them. It’s this stupid ass SOUL’s fault for all their troubles and woes. However, with their eyes off the metal sidewalk, they fail to notice someone coming straight at them. And/or, the SOUL doesn’t care to move. A hard, cold force smacks headlong into them, both bouncing off the other. Glimmer catches the knight before Adora can hit the ground, resulting in her being sent into battle (alongside Scorpia).

The robot stares down at them, *pissed.* They have wheels for feet, hands swap fingers for knives or crockscrews or anything like a swiss army knife. Their humanoid body looks like it is made out of car parts, Adora swears part of their torso is a door and their head looks like a hood.

“I’m walking here you jackasses!” they shout.

“S-Sorry!” Scopia apologizes. “We don’t have to fight.”

“C’mon, Scop!” Catra shouts from the sidelines. “Kick their ass, babe!”

Scorpia turns a bright red, shortly followed by Catra, who remains frozen in place. Glimmer, Bow, and Adora snicker at the slip up but the angry robot cuts everyone off. In all fights beforehand, the

SOUL always made the first move. Never have they been on the defensive right off the bat. But this robot is *aggressive.*

It throws back its arms, fingers all sharp, miniature knives. In one swift moment, hundreds sail through the air, poised to strike the stunned SOUL. It moves around as fast as it can, dodging the sharp object. It only does so much, however. A few of the attacks slice across the red heart. With no time to defend themselves, everyone takes a hard loss of health. Adora hiss through their teeth, biting back the rising pain. They really do not want to be caught in another death cycle here.

“What the hell was that?!?” Glimmer shouts. “How did it attack us first?!?”

"I have no idea,” Adora replies. They grip their sword tight in their hands. “But we can’t let it trip us up.”

“Then tell us what to do,” Scorpia says.

I wish I could do that.

The SOUL debates on what to do. Fight? ACT? Defend? There is no way to spare yet. Even then, the ACTs that are there the SOUL decides on one Adora doesn’t expect.

**Insult.*

"What?” Glimmer says. “Isn’t it already pissed off enough?”

“I-” Adora starts. They really don’t want to anger this monster any more than it has been. Plus, the command is for all of them. Scorpia can’t insult anyone to save her life. Catra honestly is the best pick for this job. The knight tries to finish their sentence, even though they have no idea what to say, but they cannot get anything out more than a stammer. Whatever they want today is pushed away.

**Insult.*

“Are you sure about this? You don’t want to try anything else?” Scorpia asks.

“N-”

Once again, their own words are cut off, ensnared in an invisible trap in their throat. Adora struggles to keep a forgien command from escaping from their lips. Their sword shakes from their grip, a battle waging inside them. All that comes out at first is a choking noise before they finally lose the fight.

**Insult.*

“Um, okay.”

Scorpia and Glimmer exchange looks before attempting to do what is asked of them. The scorpion monster shifts on her feet before finally saying something, with a stammer. “Y-You, uh, don’t look good.”

“Ah, christ, Scorpia,” Catra slaps her forehead. “Fuck it!”

Somehow, to everyone’s shock, the magicat forces herself onto the battlefield. She whispers something into Scorpia’s ears, to which the taller of the two looks at her in shock. Catra gives a nod and thumbs up. With a pat on the back, she scurries back over to the sidelines shouting, “You can do it, Scorp! I believe in ya!”

With a deep inhale, Scorpia tries once more to insult the being in front of her. “Your car parts look so old, they don’t look second hand. They look third hand and the playground wouldn’t even want your tire bits.”

“That's better! Hell yeah!” Catra cheers.

The monster looks at themself, confused. “The hell did you say?!? I paid top dark bucks for these!”

"Where? At the ninety-nine cent store?” Glimmer retorts.

Steam begins to pour out of the monster. They throw more knives at the group, but in their anger it goes all over the place. The SOUL easily dodges the erratic attacks, not even getting a single slice across its body. Feeling high from not taking any hits, it commands everyone to insult again. Over and over again, the insults fly and the knives lose their accuracy. Finally, fed up or tired or annoyed or whatever, the monster backs down and zooms away, never to be seen again.

“Wow that guy sure was a woose.” Catra states. She skips back over to Scorpia, patting her on the back. “We still gotta work on your insults but did you see them hightail it out of there?!?”

The chatter from everyone slowly becomes static in Adora’s ears. Unable to understand one word from the other, the knight looks at the SOUL inside of them, staring it down. They refuse to lose this war for their body. And the thing inside of them needs to know it. Adora’s fingers hover near their chest. There is one way control can be given back to them.

"Adora, are you there?” Bow asks.

“What?” Adora blinks, looking back up. He has broken away from the group, all who look from far. The knight quickly diverts their gaze away from the others, trying to stay focused only on Bow. “Yeah, what’s up?”

“You looked like you were struggling with something during that fight. And you...how do I put this,” Bow takes a moment to think. “You didn’t sound like yourself either.”

Adora bites back words crawling out of their throat. They don’t want this damn thing inside of them to say anything they don’t want. Swallowing hard, Adora forces words back down, making their stomach twist. Are they going to throw something else up? No, they won’t let that happen either. Instead, Adora gets what they actually want out. Albeit, forced.

“It’s...It’s nothing. Just a-a long d-day.”

“Are you sure?”

More forcing back words that do not belong to them. “Yes. We n-need to get to the f-fountain. Let’s g-go.”

Adora moves shaking legs forward, the SOUL taking the hint. They take a quick glance back, looking at their little group. Everyone is slowly falling into line, worried expressions on each of their faces. The knight does their best to ignore it. There is a mission at hand. Whether or not they have something controlling them inside, Adora still wants to ensure the safety of others, especially those they love.

Everyone does their best to avoid bumping into others. Fighting when not necessary is the best course of action. Try as they might, it is easier said than done. Sometimes upon bumping into someone, they do not take kindly to it. Many of those who start up a battle their bodies are made up of car parts and different types of tools. Drills, wrenches, blowtorches, you name it. A few are composed of nothing but wires, metal tubes, and wheels. All enemies fought are pretty tough, no one ever wanting to back down.

Sometimes, Adora does not bother fighting the SOUL inside of them, letting it do as it pleases. Other times, they struggle against the ACTs they decide, such as more insults or fighting when they don’t want to. Adora must choose when to do so. Each time they battle for control of their body, the more energy is sapped out of their bones. The more the SOUL has the chance to keep itself in the control room. The knight, not wanting to mess up the gears of an enemy rather oil it to get it going more, fights for said control. It leaves them tired, seeing black spec dance around their vision.

Said battle is lost and leaves Adora wobbling. Glimmer pushes herself up against her partner, keeping them up on their feet. The knight mumbles a thank you, keeping their weight on their girlfriend. When they spot a save point nearby, Adora suggests taking a break there. Everyone settles down under a sidewalk shed, shielding them from any possible falling debris. Even with

marking their spot, their health being restored, none of Adora's energy is restored. *Fuck.*

"How are you feeling?" Glimmer asks. She digs out more water for Adora to sip down.

"Fine. Just tired." Adora admits.

"Are you still up for doing this," Catra asks. "I still don't see a fountain and if I am being honest, all these robots are getting on my nerves."

"Shouldn't you know a thing or two about them since your dad works as a mechanic?"

Catra shrugs. "I only know a little, not that much. But also don't change the subject. We can always try tomorrow to close this, can't we?"

"Maybe," Bow answers. "Never thought about that before."

"You're the one who wanted to come today." Adora tells Catra.

"I wouldn't've if I knew you still were acting off."

"I'm fine. I-" Adora thinks for a moment, trying to come up with a plausible lie. They are too slow.

**Didn't get much sleep, that's all.*

Everyone looks at each other, wondering if what they are saying is true. Adora bites their lower lip, hoping the lie they did not create will work. Scorpia is the one who speaks first. "Are you still sure you don't want to go home? I'm sure the fountain can wait. It's okay to take a break."

**No. We need to keep moving.*

Adora feels themself rising to their feet without their own command. The knight curses under their breath, wishing they

could actually have a moment's rest. But what's said is said. There is no way they can snap at the words and swallow them back down their throat. It seems the only thing they can do is curl their hands into tight fist and continue what the SOUL had been saying.

"With any luck, we'll be near the fountain soon. I can rest after that, ya know?" Adora manages to stop in their tracks, turning around with a fake smile on their face. "I think we are getting close anyway. I can feel it in my gut."

Another exchange of looks, more worried looks. The SOUL forces Adora's feet to start moving again. There is no time to argue. Everyone scrambles to their feet, quickly falling back in line behind Adora.

Adora's gut was right. After several turns and dodging others, they finally reach the fountain. It spews out of an open manhole at the end of a street, a large building ending the pathway. Equipment has been abandoned and the lid to the hole is nowhere in sight, as if it has been blown sky high. Adora stops everyone with their arm. When nothing happens, they take another step. They cross an invisible threshold.

Everything that is lying around, and things flying out of windows (breaking some) all become magnetized, sticking together to create something new. Car parts, gears, metal sheets, and broken bits form most of its body. A thick torso and four legs with claws. A tail forms from a forgotten excavator. It's long neck ends with their teeth made out of sharp, spinning drills and the eyes at the top of a TV screen. It lights up to reveal red glowing eyes. It rears back before slamming their feet to the ground, causing a mini earthquake. As it roars, jagged metal bits spew forth.

Let's get this over with.

Adora pulls out their sword. Catra and Bow stand at their side, ready for the fight ahead. The SOUL seems eager to get this battle going. It right away commands everyone to fight. Adora's sword, Catra's axe, and an arrow from Bow all strike at the

towering monster. Upon being hit, things fly off of the beast. It groans in pain before shaking everything off. Now it is its turn.

With its tail, it scoops up large pieces of metal, some chuck almost as big as boulders. The pieces are hard to dodge, the SOUL takes a good amount of hits, causing everyone to wince back in pain. Adora grits their teeth as they let the ache fade away. The SOUL takes its time to figure out what else to do. Anything else that might work in their favor.

It decides to try some ACTs. The gears that make up its body all connect at its joints. Everyone's sight and aim turns towards knocking them off. First things first, it's legs, starting with the front. The gears only move slightly, slowing it down but not knocking off. Enraged, the monster retaliates with even more debris. The SOUL barely makes it out of this. There is only enough food to go around and they need to make their own advances. With a swig of Catra's axe, the left arm finally comes crashing down. Three more remain.

But that is not the only thing that comes down. Bits of its side come down as well, exposing its insides. Adora notices a mechanical heart inside. At first, they think nothing of it. However, upon second glance, they notice it looks different. It's not anatomically correct. It looks more like something someone would draw. Like the one inside of them. While it could be pure chance, nothing to write home about, it sends a cold shiver down their spine.

It's too close for comfort.

Adora figures to continue knocking off it's limbs. They can ignore the beating heart. They even remark to their comrades to keep doing as such. However, just as Adora is getting those words out, they are cut off by the SOUL.

**Go for the heart.*

“Are you sure about that?” Bow asks. “I thought we were going for the limbs?”

**Go for the heart.*

Fuck. You. Adora growls internally.

“You’re the boss,” Catra shrugs. She tosses her axe at the monster. It *definitely* does not like this. In retaliation, it slams it’s good leg on the ground, causing another small earthquake and sending up broken bits of metal and tools. It’s enough to connect with the SOUL for a final time. Adora has just enough time to brace themself for the familiar pain about to burst through their whole body.

The same motions take place. Fire exploding out of the center of their chest. The same string of words that encourages them to keep moving forward. The SOUL deciding to continue onward. And the darkness changing back into familiar metal surrounding from yards prior. Adora gasps as they readjust to being back into reality.

A shaking hand hovers over their chest, fingers once more wishing to grasp the heart. Rip it clean out. What the fuck was that about? What made it change its mind like that? Wouldn’t the best thing be immobilizing the monster? Why couldn’t *they* make that decision?

The SOUL pushes them forward, forcing them to do more things out of their control. A growl escapes their lips, loud enough for everyone around Adora to hear.

“What the hell was that?” Catra asks. She steps in front of Adora. “Are you okay? What the hell is going on with you?”

**Nothing.*

“I know you are lying out of your ass.”

**We are close to the fountain. We have to keep moving.*

The SOUL forces them forward, a shoulder smacking against Catra's. Adora wonders what the hell goes though the SOUL's mind with some of the decisions it makes. The knight does not bother looking over their shoulder. They do not want to see the looks on their faces. Ones they know are of shock, confusion, and surely disappointment. After a pause, footsteps fill the air.

As they walk closer and closer to their destination, Adora repeats over and over again in their head ' *Go for the limbs! Go for the limbs! Go for the limbs!'* Maybe if they keep repeating the command they want, they can have better control and force the SOUL to do *their* bidding.

When they come face to face with the monster again, the SOUL and Adora agree briefly. A leg crumbles to the ground quickly, pieces scattering all over the ground. Once more, it's beating heart is exposed. After dodging chucks of the ground, getting away with only minor injuries, Adora digs their heels into the metal ground and grips their sword so hard, they swear their knuckles are turning white under their covering. They refuse to yield from their plan of attack.

While one battle takes place outside, another begins inside. Adora does everything in their power to keep the SOUL on the option to take down the gears. It fights with them, wishing to move to attacking the heart. Adora feels sweat dripping from the side of their face in their struggle, their own heart beating hard against their chest. Every inch of their body shakes as it does not know who to take the command from.

"Adora?" Glimmer asks, having swapped out with Bow. "You okay, love?"

"Yeah. What the hell has gotten into you? What do you want us to do?"

**Attack the-*

Adora snaps their mouth shut, stopping the words. Instead, they get what they want out. “The other leg!”

“You sure? You don’t sound like it.”

**N-*

“Yes! D-Do it!”

Glimmer and Catra do what they are told. Having one leg down, it’s easy to get the other down. The front of the monster crashes to the ground, it’s back legs struggling to keep itself up. More of its heart is exposed. The monster snorts, blowing out steam before launching another attack. Instead of scooping up parts of the ground, the tail scrapes against the buildings, picking up even larger projectiles. It uses all the strength in their body to throw everything towards the SOUL. With the battle for control going on, the SOUL fails to move out of the way.

It shatters.

The SOUL uses the moment of pain and confusion Adora experiences to push them forward immediately. Adora has *had* it. They dig their heels in further, forcing the SOUL to drag them against the metal ground. Heels scrape, catching everyone’s attention.

“Adora?!?” Everyone shouts together.

It’s Glimmer’s hand that wraps around their wrist. A feeble move as she begins to get dragged along. “What the hell has gotten into you?”

Adora doesn’t entirely hear her. All their attention is on the SOUL inside of them. It will only be a matter of yards before they enter the boss batter once more. The knight will no longer stand for this.

“I am ***not*** letting you boss me around anymore!”

In one swift and smooth motion, Adora sends their hand through both metal and their body. Fingers grip the SOUL tight. Invisible tendrils keep the SOUL in place, making it harder for the knight to rip it from their body. They gasp, pain both from returning after dying and this causes tears to stream from their eyes. Everything blurs around them, they feel the world spinning around. But, they refuse to let go. Adora grits their teeth hard before finally yanking the SOUL clean out of their chest.

With the last of their strength, Adora uses their time as a pitcher to chuck the SOUL as far as possible. Their legs give out, their body toppling backwards. Glimmer catches them, wings wrapping around her partner's body as she gently guides them to the ground. Adora blinks back the blur and specs of black. The SOUL comes into focus, zooming around the ground in the direction of them.

"Catch it! Catch it! Catch it!" Adora shouts.

Glimmer sticks out a hand, sending a ball of light at the SOUL. It opens up wide, scooping up the heart, before snapping shut. Like when in the birdcage, the SOUL tries finding a way out. However, it is all in vain. There is no escape. Catra is the one who picks up the trapped heart.

"What the hell is this?" Catra asks. She gives it a shake, bouncing the SOUL against the ball. Bad move. Everyone in the whole group feels that and winces in pain. The magicat hiss through her teeth. "Fuck. Okay, no shaking."

"Isn't that your SOUL?" Bow inquires, stepping up to the magicat.

"N-No," Adora says out of breath. They lean their whole weight against Glimmer, no strength to be found. "It's not m-mine."

"What do you mean?" Scorpia asks.

"Every…" Adora takes a moment to let words form in their head. "Everything I have been telling you to do...so much of my guidance...things I sometimes know when I shouldn't. It's all

because of *that!* It makes me do things. It makes me give you orders. It's…"

"It's the reason you've been acting odd?" Glimmer finishes.

"Yeah. Been pissing me off lately. I...I couldn't take it anymore." Adora debates telling them about the save points. How it feels like to die over and over and over again. "I didn't like being its fuckin' puppet. But, it's the reason I can get Catra and Scorpia into the Dark World. It's how I close the fountains. I just…"

"Hey, it's okay." Bow reassures.

"Why didn't you say something sooner?" Catra asks. "I mean, you even got in trouble with your mom and dad."

"Didn't wanna worry anyone...I still wanted to come to the Dark World to see you all."

Glimmer sighs through her nose before wrapping her arms tighter around Adora's body. She places a small kiss on their temple. "It's okay."

"We still gotta close that fountain…"

"Then let's do it together." Catra begins walking forward. Glimmer pulls one of Adora's arms around her shoulders, lifting them up to their feet. Everyone follows behind the magicat as best they can.

Quick on her feet, by the time everyone is in the area, Catra is right at the spewing fountain. The SOUL already is out, ready to close it. "Don't you try any shit," Catra growls as she watches it. The moment the fountain is shut, the magicat snaps the ball trap over the SOUL, sealing it once more. She spins around on her heels. "Well that was easy."

"Awwww, I didn't get to show off my creation!" an unfamiliar voice echoes through the area.

Everyone snaps their head up, searching around for the owner. Out of one of the windows, the heart Adora saw before floats down. The moment it lands on the ground, it splits in two and opens up. An older woman appears, parts of her body made of robotic parts. She uses her purple hair as legs, searching around the area. “I was so excited.”

“Uhh...Are you the princess?” Glimmer questions.

“Yes I am! Princess Entrapta!”

“You...You were going to create that monster?” Adora asks. *So going after the heart was a bad idea! Suck it!*

“Yes.” Entrapta sighs, looking sad.

“Um...Well...I am sure I have things you can use back in Brightmoon to build new things. How does that sound?” Glimmer offers.

Entrapta’s red eyes light up. “Oh! I would love that.”

“That sure was easy...Adora. What do you want to do?”

Adora knows exactly what they want to do. “I just want to go home.”

Saturday. No school. Nothing to worry about. They even got home early yesterday, the sun was still shining when they exited the Dark World. Caracal did not question anything, only wishing everyone well and hoping his daughter isn’t pulling them into too much mischief. Not much else was really said as Adora headed home. What really could be said? Nothing. The moment Adora got home, they ate their dinner, and then went straight to bed.

Sleep, however, was rare. Maybe for a few moments did Adora slip into the first stage of slumber. Only a brief period of time passes before the world comes back to them. No matter how hard they wanted to sleep, their body wouldn't allow it. Adora can help but

laugh at that thought. Finally got rid of the blasted SOUL and their body *still* refuses to listen to them.

Morning light now streams in and their mother will be calling them down to breakfast any moment now. If she has called, they don't know. Their eyes haven't left the ball sitting on their nightstand. Somehow, they managed to sneak it in without either of their parents noticing it. It's an odd feeling, no longer having the SOUL inside their body. They *are* happy to have control of their actions once more. But...there is an odd emptiness in their chest. Though, they did have it inside for who knows how long. Should it be surprising that a deep part of them wants to shove it back inside?

Adora shakes the thought from their mind. No. It's better if it is out. Better they are no longer a puppet for someone else's amusement. The only reason the SOUL is kept around so they can return to the Dark World until something else can be figured out.

I still hate you. Adora thinks to themself.

"Adora, honey! Come downstairs!" Randor's voice shouts.

Better get up before they come check on me…

As Adora slowly rises into a sitting position, their mother's words enter their room. "We have some surprises for you!"

"Huh?" Adora blinks. They quickly get dressed and make their way down the single flight of stairs. What in the world are their surprises?

"What's up, Ma?" Adora turns the corner. They stop short, eyes going wide. In the middle of their living room, there are many bodies. Their parents, Catra, and Scorpia (who now are holding hands). To their bewilderment, Glimmer and Bow somehow are here also. They no longer look like their Darkner selves. No wings, no pointed ears. Glimmer still has her two toned hair but that's about it.

"Uh, what the hell is going on." Adora asks.

“We figured to chill out and relax here today!” Catra says. She lets go of Scorpia’s claw and wraps an arm around Adora. She leans close to their ear. “Before we left the Dark World yesterday, Scorp and I talked to Bow and Glimmer. We figured give you a break from getting us there, ya know?”

“You didn’t have to do that, none of you. But...thanks,” Adora replies.

“Anytime.” Catra gives them a small punch to the ribcage.

“So,” a familiar voice starts. It causes Adora’s heart to skip in their chest. Out of the crowd, their older brother appears. His dark hair still is tied back into a small ponytail. Dark blue eyes peer out of his bang and stubble is on his chin. He has his university jacket on and his backpack hanging off one shoulder. “Am I chopped liver now? You get yourself a girlfriend, so does Cat, and y’all get into trouble. The hell are you doing without me, ‘Dora?”

“Adam!” Adora throws themself on their brother. Adam wraps his arms around his little sibling, happy to embrace them again. Adora buries their face into his shoulder. “I missed you. What are you doing here? Break still isn’t for a bit!”

“Eh, I heard you were having a bit of a hard time so I wanted to check up on you. Seems like everyone is. You are in good hands, ya know?”

Adora pulls away, looking around the room. A soft smile forms on their face and they wipe a small tear from their face. “Yeah. Yeah, I love all of you guys. Thanks.”

Marlena claps her hands together. “Well, with a house full there is going to be a lot of cooking done! All of you are chipping in!”

There is no complaining. Everyone begins to help out, pulling ingredients out of the fridge and cupboards. Messes are made, laughter fills the air, and anything thought about the SOUL is pushed far, *far* away. Movies and video games are played. By the time late afternoon is reached, a fort made of pillows and sheets

rests in the middle of the living room. Adora snuggles up against Glimmer, overjoyed the angel is here in the flesh. Bow and Adam rest nearby, chatting about 'guy stuff'. Finally, after admitting their feelings during the brief period Adora didn't see them yesterday, Catra and Scorpia cuddle together.

Everything Adora has done today was on their own terms. And their girlfriend, friends, and family all helped make it better. The sleep they could not find before starts to creep along their body.

"Rest up, love. You deserve it," Glimmer whispers under her breath. "We will keep an eye on everything for once."

"You guys are the best. We still gotta figure out what to do with the SOUL and fountains though." Adora tries to keep their eyes open but it is a losing battle.

"We will figure that out later, 'kay? Rest."

"Okay…"

And finally, for once, they get a good rest.

Chapter End Notes

Comments/kudos appreciated

End Notes

comments/kudos appreciated!

I forgot also but I commissioned Kaereth for Deltarune Adora so here is what they would look like

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!